

Polarized Media and Inflation Expectations^{*}

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Abstract

We study how politically polarized television news shapes household inflation expectations in Turkey. We combine new household panel data with transcript-based measures of channel-level inflation coverage during prime-time news and a large-scale randomized information experiment. Inflation coverage differs sharply across politically aligned channels, and viewers sort into outlets consistent with their political affiliations. Within-person estimates show that greater coverage on a respondent's initially preferred channel leads to higher inflation expectations, with effects concentrated among viewers of politically neutral channels. Experimental evidence indicates that belief updating depends on prior anchoring as well as on source credibility and reveals the political costs of rising inflation expectations.

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1. Introduction

Inflation expectations are central to households’ intertemporal choices and to the transmission of monetary policy, yet households rarely observe the full state of the macroeconomy directly. Instead, they form beliefs using a combination of personal price exposure, public statistics, and intermediated information (Carroll, 2003; D’Acunto, Malmendier, Ospina, and Weber, 2021). The media is therefore a natural channel through which economic news can shape expectations (Dräger, 2015; De Fiore, Maurin, Mijakovic, and Sandri, 2024). In politically polarized environments, however, media outlets may filter and frame macroeconomic developments in ways that reflect outlet ideology and audience demand, potentially generating systematically different beliefs among households exposed to different news sources (Alesina, Miano, and Stantcheva, 2020; Bursztyn, Rao, Roth, and Yanagizawa-Drott, 2023). These forces are likely to be especially important when inflation is high and volatile: inflation is salient enough to attract attention, but households may still disagree about its causes, persistence, and policy implications (Andre, Haaland, Roth, Wiederholt, and Wohlfart, 2026). We study how politically segmented television news shapes household inflation expectations in Turkey, a high-inflation economy with a polarized media landscape.

We combine panel data on households’ inflation expectations with detailed information on respondents’ preferred prime-time news channels and measures of channel-specific inflation coverage constructed from television transcripts. We find that greater inflation coverage is associated with higher household inflation expectations, even after exploiting within-individual variation in exposure and accounting for political affiliation and local conditions. This relationship is driven almost entirely by viewers of politically neutral channels. A complementary randomized information experiment shows that this heterogeneity reflects differences in how audiences update their beliefs rather than differences in the informational content of the media they consume.

Our empirical analysis builds on a new dataset that links household inflation expectations to the economic content of the television news respondents report watching. We combine a monthly household panel with information on each respondent’s preferred prime-time news channel and collect transcripts of prime-time broadcasts from publicly available video archives. We then use text-analysis methods to construct channel-month measures of inflation coverage and the tone of inflation-related news. Matching these measures to respondents’ reported viewing choices allows us to study how variation in the supply of inflation news across television outlets is reflected in household inflation expectations.

A central empirical challenge is that households endogenously select the news sources they consume. In a cross section, respondents with high or low inflation expectations may

choose television channels whose coverage is consistent with their prior beliefs, confounding media exposure with selective sorting. We address this concern by exploiting the panel structure of the survey and studying within-individual variation in inflation coverage on the respondent’s preferred news channel. This design absorbs time-invariant differences in households’ political views, media preferences, information sets, and baseline inflation beliefs, and identifies the relationship between changes in channel-level inflation coverage and changes in expectations for the same respondent over time.

A remaining concern is that respondents may change their preferred news source in response to changes in either media coverage or their own inflation beliefs. To limit this form of dynamic selection, we assign each respondent to the channel they report watching when they first enter the survey and hold this assignment fixed throughout the panel. The estimated exposure measure therefore varies only because the initially preferred channel changes its inflation coverage over time, not because respondents subsequently switch across channels. In practice, such switching is infrequent in our data, but fixing the initial channel choice ensures that the identifying variation comes from changes in channel-level coverage rather than from endogenous changes in respondents’ reported media choices. The identifying assumption is therefore that, conditional on the fixed effects and controls described below, changes in inflation coverage of the initially preferred channel are not driven by unobserved changes in the inflation expectations of that channel’s initial viewers.

A further identification concern is that television channels may adjust their coverage in response to the economic concerns of their audience. If channels cater to viewers’ demand for inflation news, then changes in coverage may partly reflect changes in viewers’ underlying inflation perceptions or expectations rather than independent variation in the media environment. We address this concern in two ways. First, we control directly for respondents’ past inflation exposures, which are important predictors of household inflation expectations (D’Acunto, Malmendier, Ospina, and Weber, 2021a; D’Acunto, Malmendier, and Weber, 2021b). Second, we show that channel-level inflation coverage is not systematically related to the past inflation perceptions of the respondents assigned to that channel. These tests reduce the concern that our estimates merely capture endogenous catering to viewers’ inflation exposure.

We further account for time-varying political and local economic shocks that could jointly affect media coverage and expectations. Because viewers sort into channels along partisan lines, changes in inflation coverage may coincide with party-specific political communication or narratives that independently shape households’ beliefs. Similarly, local economic conditions may affect both respondents’ inflation expectations and the news agenda of channels with geographically concentrated audiences. Our preferred specifications therefore compare

respondents with the same party affiliation, in the same month, and in the same province-month environment, but who are assigned to different initially preferred television channels. These fixed effects absorb time-varying partisan and local shocks, leaving identification to come from differential changes in inflation coverage across channels within narrowly defined political and geographic cells.

The panel estimates show that greater inflation coverage on a respondent’s initially preferred television channel leads to higher inflation expectations. A one-standard-deviation increase in inflation coverage is associated with an increase in inflation expectations of roughly 10 percent of their standard deviation. We obtain similar, and in some specifications larger, estimates when using variation in the television news agenda around local elections as an instrument for inflation coverage: as election-related news crowds out economic reporting, inflation coverage falls, generating plausibly exogenous shifts in the salience of inflation in the news. These IV estimates support the interpretation that changes in media coverage affect expectations, although the exclusion restriction requires that election-related news affects inflation expectations only through its effect on inflation coverage.

The average relationship masks substantial heterogeneity. The response is concentrated among viewers of politically neutral channels, for whom the estimated effect is more than three times larger. By contrast, viewers of pro-government and pro-opposition channels display little systematic response to changes in inflation coverage. The fact that tone matters less than coverage itself suggests that media exposure operates primarily by increasing the salience of inflation or by cueing memories of past inflationary episodes (D’Acunto et al., 2021a; Bordalo, Gennaioli, and Shleifer, 2022, 2020; Braggion, Von Meyerinck, Schaub, and Weber, 2024).

The panel evidence points to a strong and heterogeneous relationship between television coverage and inflation expectations, but it does not by itself identify why audiences respond differently across media environments. The muted response among viewers of partisan channels could reflect strong politically anchored priors that make them less willing to update in response to new inflation news. Alternatively, it could reflect limited time-series variation in the coverage of partisan outlets, which tend to discuss inflation either persistently little or persistently often, making effects harder to estimate in a panel design. Conversely, the strong response among viewers of neutral channels may reflect weaker priors, greater general openness to economic information, or greater trust in the outlets they normally watch. To distinguish among these mechanisms, we complement the panel analysis with a large-scale randomized information experiment embedded in a separate survey.

The experiment first elicits respondents’ prior inflation expectations and their preferred news sources, and then randomly exposes them to short inflation-related news narratives.

The treatments vary the narrative shown to respondents and the television outlet to which the narrative is attributed, mirroring the way inflation is typically framed by pro-government, pro-opposition, and politically neutral outlets. A positive narrative emphasizes factors that may reduce inflation, while a negative one emphasizes factors that may raise inflation. We then elicit posterior inflation expectations and compare belief updating across respondents with different baseline media preferences. This design allows us to test whether heterogeneous updating reflects the informational content of inflation news, the perceived credibility of the source, or differences in the strength of respondents’ prior beliefs.

We find that viewers of neutral channels update their priors no matter which narrative or news outlet they are randomly exposed to. The experiment also reveals politically asymmetric updating among viewers of partisan channels. Viewers of pro-government channels are generally less responsive to inflation narratives, but they revise their expectations when the information is attributed to a pro-government outlet. This pattern suggests that politically aligned source credibility can partly overcome otherwise limited belief updating among these respondents. In contrast, viewers of pro-opposition channels do not systematically update in response to any treatment, regardless of the source to which the information is attributed. Their lack of responsiveness is consistent with strongly anchored prior beliefs or saturation: for these viewers, inflation may already be sufficiently salient that additional inflation-related information has little marginal effect. Interestingly, their lack of belief updating in response to treatments resembles those of respondents who normally prefer not to watch any TV channel. Taken together, the experimental evidence suggests that media effects depend not only on the content of economic news, but also on the interaction between audience priors and perceived source credibility.

We also use the experimental setting to study whether inflation expectations affect policy and political preferences. Among viewers of politically neutral channels, the information treatments generate variation in posterior inflation expectations that allows us to estimate the broader effects of belief updating. The estimates suggest that higher inflation expectations reduce support for heterodox monetary-policy views, lower confidence in the government’s economic management, and decrease stated willingness to support the incumbent party or its followers. These results are consistent with the broader political economy relevance of inflation expectations, although the estimates are less precise than our main expectation results and should be interpreted as suggestive evidence on political consequences.

This paper makes three main contributions. First, we provide new evidence on the formation of household inflation expectations in a high-inflation emerging-market environment. Existing work has shown that households’ inflation expectations respond to personal price exposures, public information, and media coverage, but much of the evidence comes from

advanced economies with relatively stable inflation and better-anchored expectations (Carroll, 2003; Dräger, 2015; D’Acunto et al., 2021; Coibion, Gorodnichenko, and Weber, 2022; De Fiore et al., 2024). Turkey provides a useful setting in which to study these mechanisms because inflation is high, volatile, politically salient, and economically consequential. This setting allows us to examine how media coverage shapes expectations when households pay close attention to inflation but may disagree about its causes, persistence, and policy implications.

Second, we introduce a new empirical design that links household-level inflation expectations to the economic content of the television news respondents report watching. We combine a monthly household panel with channel-specific transcripts of prime-time television broadcasts and construct measures of inflation coverage and tone at the channel-month level. This measurement strategy allows us to study how changes in the supply of inflation news across television outlets are reflected in changes in expectations among the households initially attached to those outlets. By fixing respondents’ initial channel choices and absorbing individual, party-month, and local time-varying shocks, the panel design substantially reduces concerns about selective exposure and common confounders. We then complement this evidence with a randomized information experiment that directly varies exposure to inflation narratives and the source to which those narratives are attributed.

Third, we contribute to the literature on political polarization, media segmentation, and economic belief formation. In politically polarized environments, households may not merely receive different economic information; they may also interpret similar information differently depending on prior beliefs and perceived source credibility (Alesina et al., 2020; Bursztyn et al., 2023; DellaVigna and Gentzkow, 2010). Our results show that the effect of inflation coverage is concentrated among viewers of politically neutral channels, while viewers of partisan channels are much less responsive to changes in coverage. Experimental evidence indicates that this heterogeneity reflects the interaction between audience priors and politically aligned source credibility. The findings therefore show how polarized media environments can shape macroeconomic expectations and, more broadly, how political segmentation can weaken the common information base on which expectation formation depends.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the related literature. Section 3 describes the construction of the panel dataset, outlines the empirical methodology and presents the regression results. Section 4 discusses the experimental design and the mechanisms revealed by the RCT. Section 5 concludes.

2. Related Literature

Our paper contributes to several strands of the literature on household inflation expectations, such as the literature on rational inattention, media effects, political polarization, and central bank credibility.

2.1. Inflation Expectations, Attention, and Information Rigidities

Our analysis builds on the literature that studies inflation expectations under information frictions. A central insight of this work is that households do not continuously observe and process all macroeconomic information. Instead, they update beliefs intermittently or selectively, generating disagreement, sluggish adjustment, and sensitivity to the information sources households encounter (Mankiw and Reis, 2002; Carroll, 2003; Sims, 2003; Reis, 2006; Coibion and Gorodnichenko, 2015). In Carroll’s epidemiological model, for example, professional forecasts diffuse gradually to households through the media, so media coverage can affect both the speed and the extent of belief updating (Carroll, 2003). More recent work shows that household inflation expectations also respond to personally exposed prices and other salient information, implying that belief formation is shaped by both aggregate signals and individual exposure (Cavallo, Cruces, and Perez-Truglia, 2017; D’Acunto et al., 2021; D’Acunto et al., 2021b).

Most empirical evidence on household inflation expectations comes from advanced economies in which inflation was low and relatively stable for much of the available sample period. In such environments, limited attention to inflation is natural: the private gains from acquiring and processing inflation information are small when inflation is stable and expectations are comparatively well anchored. Consistent with this view, recent evidence shows that attention to inflation rises when inflation becomes more salient or when the cost of inattention increases (Korenok, Munro, and Chen, 2023; Pfäuti, 2023; Bracha and Tang, 2025; Weber, Candia, Afrouzi, Ropele, Lluberas, Frache, Meyer, Kumar, Gorodnichenko, Georgarakos, et al., 2025). However, the inflation rates studied in much of this literature are modest relative to the experience of many emerging markets. Turkey therefore provides a useful setting for examining whether the same mechanisms operate when inflation is not merely above target, but persistently high, volatile, and politically contested.

High inflation can affect information frictions in two opposing ways. On the one hand, it raises the economic stakes of inflation developments and should increase attention to inflation-related information. On the other hand, volatility in realized inflation, disagreement about official statistics, and uncertainty about future policy may prevent households from forming precise and stable priors. In such an environment, greater attention need not imply

weaker responses to new information. Instead, households may pay more attention while still placing substantial weight on new signals because their priors remain diffuse. This logic is consistent with evidence that learning from information treatments is stronger when prior uncertainty is high or central bank credibility is weak (Weber et al., 2025).

Our setting allows us to study this interaction between attention, prior uncertainty, and information supply. During our sample period, inflation in Turkey was both high and volatile, and television coverage of inflation varied substantially across outlets. We examine whether this variation in media coverage is reflected in household inflation expectations and whether responsiveness differs across audiences exposed to different media environments. In doing so, the paper extends the literature on information rigidities to a setting in which inflation is highly salient but expectations are weakly anchored, making the media a potentially important source of both information and disagreement.

2.2. Media Coverage and Expectation Formation

A growing literature studies the role of media coverage for the formation of household inflation expectation. In the epidemiological model of Carroll (2003), media coverage is the channel through which professional and public information diffuses gradually to households. Subsequent empirical work shows that inflation expectations are related to the amount, content, and tone of inflation news households encounter (Pfajfar and Santoro, 2013; Lamla and Lein, 2014; Dräger, 2015; Dräger and Lamla, 2017; Ehrmann, Pfajfar, and Santoro, 2017; Larsen, Thorsrud, and Zhulanova, 2021; Macaulay and Song, 2023; Larsen, Maffei-Faccioli, and Pagenhardt, 2025). This literature establishes that media coverage can help explain disagreement, sluggish updating, and movements in aggregate inflation expectations. Much of the existing evidence, however, relies on aggregate media measures or survey data from advanced economies with relatively stable inflation expectations.

Recent work also emphasizes that the media does not simply transmit an exogenous flow of economic information. Media outlets select which topics to cover, and the decision to cover inflation may itself be informative to households. Nimark and Pitschner (2019) develop a framework in which the media acts as a delegated information processor, choosing which news is sufficiently important to report. In this view, topic selection is not neutral: even before households process the content or tone of a story, the fact that inflation receives attention may signal that inflation is economically important. Consistent with this mechanism, Chahrour, Shapiro, and Wilson (2025) show that news selection can shape household inflation expectations, and Larsen et al. (2021) provide evidence that media topic selection predicts public expectations.

Our paper contributes to this literature by linking household-level expectations to channel-specific television content in a politically segmented media environment. Rather than relying on aggregate media indicators, we observe respondents’ preferred news channels and construct channel-month measures of inflation coverage and tone from prime-time television transcripts. This measurement allows us to compare households who differ in the inflation coverage supplied by the outlets they report watching, while holding fixed individual characteristics and time-varying political and local shocks. The setting is also important. Television remains a central source of economic information for many households (Blinder and Krueger, 2004), and in Turkey television news is both highly salient and politically segmented. We therefore study not only whether media coverage is related to inflation expectations, but also whether the effect of coverage depends on the political environment in which households receive and interpret economic news. Closest to our empirical approach, Binder, Frank, and Ryngaert (2025) study the causal effect of television news on inflation expectations using aggregate time-series variation. We complement their evidence by linking channel-specific television content to household-level expectations and by studying heterogeneity across politically segmented audiences.

2.3. Polarization, Media Narratives, and Monetary-Policy Credibility

Our paper also relates to the literature on political polarization, media slant, and economic belief formation. A large body of work shows that political identity shapes perceptions of economic conditions and the interpretation of public information (Alesina et al., 2020; Coibion, Gorodnichenko, and Weber, 2020; Mian, Sufi, and Khoshkhoh, 2023; Binder, Kamdar, and Ryngaert, 2024; Kamdar and Ray, 2022; Kamdar, Ray, and Ulate, 2025; Kuang, Weber, and Xie, 2024, 2025; Bowles, Larreguy, Liu, and Akbiyik, 2025). In parallel, the literature on media markets emphasizes that outlets may slant coverage in response to owner incentives, political pressure, or audience demand (Mullainathan and Shleifer, 2005; Gentzkow and Shapiro, 2010; Durante and Knight, 2012). These two forces interact when households sort into politically aligned media outlets: individuals may not only receive different economic information, but may also attach different credibility to similar information depending on the source from which it is received.

This interaction is particularly important for inflation expectations. Inflation is both a macroeconomic outcome and a politically salient signal of government performance. Politically aligned media outlets may therefore differ in how much attention they devote to inflation, how they frame its causes, and whether they emphasize policy responsibility. At the same time, viewers may discount information from politically incongruent sources or

update more strongly when information is attributed to sources they perceive as credible. Our setting allows us to study these mechanisms directly by linking household expectations to channel-specific inflation coverage and by experimentally varying the source to which inflation narratives are attributed.

The Turkish context is especially useful for studying these issues. Turkey combines high and volatile inflation with a politically segmented media environment and repeated concerns about central bank independence. Political pressure on the Central Bank of the Republic of Turkey has intensified in recent years, with government leaders frequently advocating lower interest rates and publicly criticizing tight monetary policy (Çakmaklı, Demiralp, and Güneş, 2024). When central bank credibility is weak, households may lack a common nominal anchor and may place greater weight on alternative information sources, including media narratives.¹ This mechanism is consistent with evidence that information treatments have larger effects when prior beliefs are diffuse or central bank credibility is low (Weber et al., 2025). The same environment may magnify the consequences of politically segmented media coverage: if households disagree not only about future inflation but also about the credibility of official policy, media narratives can become an important source of cross-sectional disagreement.

2.4. *Media Persuasion, Economic Beliefs, and Political Outcomes*

Finally, our paper relates to the literature on media persuasion and political behavior. A large body of work shows that media exposure can affect political attitudes, voting behavior, and polarization (DellaVigna and Gentzkow, 2010). DellaVigna and Kaplan (2007) study the effect of Fox News on Republican vote shares in the United States, Enikolopov, Petrova, and Zhuravskaya (2011) analyze the political effects of independent television in Russia, and Barone, D’Acunto, and Narciso (2015) document the electoral consequences of commercial television exposure in Italy. Related work studies how media bias, selective reporting, and political myths can shape beliefs even when agents are otherwise rational or partially informed (Besley and Prat, 2006; Kamenica and Gentzkow, 2011; Glaeser and Ward, 2006; Campante and Hojman, 2013).

We complement this literature by focusing on macroeconomic expectations as an intermediate belief outcome through which media exposure may matter for political preferences. Inflation is a particularly important object in this respect because it directly affects households’ purchasing power and can shape evaluations of incumbent economic management. Recent evidence shows that inflation shocks can have substantial political consequences, including increased support for anti-system and populist parties (Federle, Mohr, and Schu-

¹Recent papers studying how firms in Turkey form their inflation expectations are Akarsu and Aktug (2025); Seven and Duhan (2026).

larick, 2024). Our contribution is to study how politically segmented media coverage shapes the inflation expectations that may underlie such political responses. In the experimental part of the paper, we provide suggestive evidence that changes in inflation expectations affect policy views and stated political support. These results connect the media-persuasion literature to macroeconomic belief formation.

3. Panel Data, Methodology and Results

3.1. Koç University Household Inflation Expectations Survey

The Koç University Household Inflation Expectations Survey (KUHIES) was launched in January 2024 and surveys approximately 2,500 respondents per month. The sampling framework is based on population size and education levels for neighborhoods and villages from the Address-Based Population Registration System (ADNKS), combined with precinct-level results from the May 14, 2023 general elections. Residential areas are first classified as rural, urban, or metropolitan, and the sample is then stratified across 12 NUTS-1 regions.

To ensure that the sample reflects the adult population of Turkey, quotas are implemented by age, gender, education, and NUTS-1 region. After data collection, we apply post-stratification weights using the same variables, together with respondents' reported vote choice in the 2023 general elections. The weighted sample therefore closely matches the demographic, regional, and political composition of the Turkish adult population, particularly with respect to age, gender, education, and region.²

The survey elicits respondents' perceptions of inflation over the previous 12 months and their expectations for inflation over the next 12 months.³ In addition, KUHIES records respondents' preferred television channel for prime-time news, their vote choice in the 2023 general elections, and key demographic characteristics. These variables allow us to link individual inflation expectations to both political affiliation and the television news environment to which respondents are exposed.

Table 1 reports summary statistics for the main variables used in the analysis. Inflation expectations are high and dispersed: the mean expected inflation rate is 101%, with a standard deviation of 58%, and values range from 20 to 300% across 9,253 observations. Perceived inflation over the previous 12 months is somewhat higher, with a mean of 111% and a similarly large standard deviation of 55%. The fact that perceived past inflation exceeds expected future inflation is consistent with the post-2023 disinflationary period covered by

²The monthly survey reports are available at <https://case.ku.edu.tr/en/turkiye-household-inflation-expectations-survey/>.

³Figure D1 shows the within-sample distribution of inflation expectations.

our sample. Respondents are distributed across politically distinct media environments: 35.6% are assigned to pro-government channels, 17.0% to politically neutral channels, and 47.4% to pro-opposition channels. In terms of political affiliation, 37.1% report voting for the AKP in the 2023 general elections, while 62.9% report voting for another party or not voting.

3.2. *Videos/Transcripts of Prime-time News on TV*

For each of the 15 major TV channels in Turkey present in our survey of household inflation expectations, we search the publicly available video platforms on the web in order to extract the daily prime-time news videos for the period between November 2023 to December 2024. We are able to find daily news videos from 13 channels across two platforms: YouTube and Dailymotion.⁴ We first extract the corresponding links for each video and then web-scrape all the transcripts at *channel x day* level.⁵ Table C1 lists the TV channels and the corresponding number of daily news videos/transcripts that are available during our sample period.

We categorize and color-code these 13 channels into three groups of long-term political alignment (orange: pro-government, blue: neutral and black: pro-opposition) by using a zero-shot AI-based classification.⁶ In Appendix B, we discuss how this agnostic categorization correlates with the anecdotal evidence on the ownership linkages and the regulatory discrimination across TV channels in Turkey.

We base our text analysis on the transcripts that are automatically generated by the corresponding video platforms. However, we also checked the audio-to-text conversion quality of these transcripts by comparing a subset of them to those transcribed by the OpenAI’s automatic speech recognition model (i.e., Whisper) and found the results to be comparable except for spoken numbers.⁷

⁴ATV and A Haber, both of which belong to the same media conglomerate, simultaneously broadcast the same prime-time news program on their TV channels.

⁵We used a team of Turkish-speaking research assistants to manually locate and collect the links for these videos while independently confirming their performance on a subsample of entries.

⁶We use ChatGPT, Claude and DeepSeek for this prompt-based classification exercise and categorize the channels based on their average agreement across 3 groups of political alignment. Results are available upon request.

⁷See <https://openai.com/index/whisper/>. Results are available upon request. The sub-standard comparability on transcribed numbers is not a critical issue given that they constitute less than 2% of our total text corpus.

3.3. *Polarization of Inflation Coverage and News Consumption*

Our focus on prime-time television broadcasts is motivated by the continued importance of television as one of the primary sources of news consumption. While traditional newspapers once played a central role in the media landscape, their influence has declined globally due to digitization, changing news consumption patterns, and generational shifts.⁸

Data from KUHIES reveal that roughly half of respondents cite their own shopping experiences as the primary source of information about inflation, with television and radio ranking second, chosen by approximately 30 percent of respondents (See Figure A1). This pattern mirrors evidence from the United States, where personal shopping is also consistently identified as the most important source of inflation information (D’Acunto et al., 2021b,a). The secondary ranking of media may reflect a broader perception that television and newspapers are politically polarized and lack editorial independence (Coibion et al., 2022). Nevertheless, given the prominence of television in the Turkish media environment, prime-time coverage remains a particularly relevant channel through which households receive inflation-related information.

During our sample period, inflation in Turkey followed a pronounced trajectory. In the aftermath of the May 2023 elections, monetary policy remained tight throughout much of 2024. Annual inflation started the year at 65 percent, rose to a peak of 75 percent in May, and subsequently declined to 44 percent by the end of the year, reflecting both base effects and the cumulative impact of monetary tightening (see Appendix A for an overview of inflation targeting in Turkey over the last two decades).

Despite this clear inflation trajectory, television coverage of inflation did not closely track the underlying macroeconomic dynamics. Figure 1 shows the frequency with which the term “inflation” appears in prime-time TV news varies substantially across networks and does not systematically follow movements in actual inflation. These patterns also reveal a clear political polarization in inflation coverage. Opposition-leaning TV channels consistently devote more coverage to inflation, whereas pro-government channels mention inflation substantially less frequently. Neutral ones, such as Habertürk and Kanal D, display intermediate levels

⁸Evidence from international surveys highlights the changing structure of news consumption. The 2025 Reuters Institute Digital News Report shows that among users aged 18–24 across 48 markets, 44 percent cite social media and video networks as their primary news source, while television is the main source for only 20 percent of this age group. In contrast, 48 percent of adults aged 55 and older still rely primarily on television for news (Newman, Ross Arguedas, Robertson, Nielsen, and Fletcher, 2025). Overall, television as a news source has declined by 22 percentage points since 2019, with social and video networks overtaking television globally for the first time. Print newspapers have experienced particularly steep declines in circulation, as digital platforms provide real-time access to news without the costs associated with print subscriptions. A 2024 Pew Research Center study reports that only 26 percent of U.S. adults obtain news from print sources, the lowest level in their time series, while 63 percent still report watching television news at least occasionally (St. Aubin and Liedke, 2025).

of coverage. By contrast, channels such as ShowTV or Star—whose programming are less focused on news—exhibit coverage patterns closer to those of pro-government networks.

The timing of coverage also differs across political groups. Pro-government channels concentrate inflation coverage around mid-year, coinciding with pension adjustments linked to first-half inflation outcomes, a period during which inflation news can be framed in connection with benefit increases. Opposition channels, in contrast, intensify their coverage in the second half of the year, when inflation fatigue may decline and concerns about real purchasing power and minimum wage bargaining become more salient.

The classification of TV channels in Figure 1 is corroborated by survey evidence on viewers’ news preferences. Figure 2 reports the distribution of preferred TV news channels among participants in KUHIES, disaggregated by the party survey respondents voted for during 2023 general elections.⁹ The data reveal a strong pattern of partisan sorting: voters supporting the incumbent government party overwhelmingly watch pro-government channels, whereas other voters primarily follow opposition-leaning networks.¹⁰ Notably, approximately 20 percent of respondents from both political camps report watching neutral networks. This group may represent viewers who are more likely to process economic information outside of strongly partisan media environments, potentially forming inflation expectations in a less politically filtered manner. In the next section, we examine whether this distinction plays a role in shaping how households respond to inflation-related media narratives.

To measure the sentiment that captures the relative optimism or pessimism with which each television channel frames inflation, we fine-tune a pre-trained Turkish BERT model to context windows extracted from the transcripts. For every transcript in our corpus, we first identify all occurrences of the word “enflasyon” (i.e., “inflation” in Turkish and its morphological variants). Around each occurrence we extract a symmetric context window of ± 30 words, yielding a short text snippet that captures the immediate linguistic environment of the inflation mention.¹¹ Each window is then scored by a transformer model with BERT-base architecture pre-trained on Turkish product reviews for sentiment analysis, making it a natural starting point for our domain (Yildirim, 2024).¹² In order to measure inflation-related optimism/pessimism on TV news, we fine-tune this model on a set of human-labeled

⁹For respondents who have been in the survey across multiple waves, we consider only the TV channel for prime-time news preferred during their first wave.

¹⁰Patterns are very similar when we group voters based on the presidential alliance parties (AKP+MHP) vs. others as illustrated in Figure D2.

¹¹This process generates 13,526 context windows in total. Transcripts with no inflation mentions produce no windows and are thus excluded from the optimism index for the relevant channel-month cell.

¹²See <https://huggingface.co/savasy/bert-base-turkish-sentiment-cased>. The model is applied deterministically (no sampling at inference), with inputs truncated at 512 subword tokens. All computations were performed locally using PyTorch 2.6.0 and Hugging Face Transformers 4.49.0.

context windows before applying it to our full dataset.¹³

The model assigns two probabilities, $P(\text{optimistic})$ and $P(\text{pessimistic})$, that sum to one. For each transcript we compute the window-level average of both probabilities and define the transcript-level net sentiment score as:

$$s_i = \bar{P}_i(\text{optimistic}) - \bar{P}_i(\text{pessimistic}) \in [-1, 1],$$

where the bar denotes the mean over all scored windows in transcript i . A score close to +1 indicates that inflation is discussed in predominantly optimistic language; a score close to -1 indicates predominantly pessimistic language. We then collapse to the channel-month level by taking the mean of s_i across all transcripts belonging to channel c in calendar month t .¹⁴

Figure 3 illustrates that the polarization of inflation coverage extends to the way different TV channels talk about inflation during prime-time news with pro-government and pro-opposition channels lying on the opposite ends of the optimism/pessimism spectrum.¹⁵ While the time variation in inflation-related optimism is generally limited, neutral channels exhibit larger variations and opposition channels are particularly persistent in pessimistically covering the inflation throughout our sample period.¹⁶

¹³Three research assistants (RAs) independently labeled a random sample of 1,941 inflation context windows as optimistic, pessimistic, or neutral with respect to the inflation outlook implied by the text. Each window was rated by two different RAs and we dropped windows where the two-rater labels were maximally discordant (-1 vs. +1) or windows resolved as neutral, leaving 796 usable labeled windows with a class distribution of 66.6% negative and 33.4% positive. We split the labeled windows into training (70%), validation (10%), and test (%) sets using stratified sampling to preserve class balance. The resulting fine-tuned model improved its bi-directional accuracy from 76% to 92% and the beyond-chance agreement with the average RA score (i.e., Cohen’s Kappa) rose from 43% to 83%. See Appendix C and Table C2 for further details.

¹⁴To suppress noise from months with very thin coverage, we set a channel-month cell to missing whenever it contains fewer than five scored transcripts.

¹⁵In Figure C1, we present the results without fine-tuning the BERT model, representing a sentiment analysis with positive and negative scores computed in the same way as it was done for the fine-tuned model. The resulting channel-level sentiment dynamics are qualitatively very similar to the optimism/pessimism trends in Figure 3. We prefer the latter model due to its high performance relative to other benchmark models (see Table C2).

¹⁶Figure C2 shows similar patterns when we narrow or widen the word window around our keyword (“enflasyon”). Additionally, Figure C3 presents the same exercise undertaken via an open-source large language model (LLM) that can support Turkish language (see <https://ollama.com/library/qwen2.5:14b>). Both few-shot and zero-shot versions show similar cross-sectional patterns though they seem to be generally biased downward compared to our preferred model in Figure 3. See Appendix C for the details of the LLM exercise.

3.4. Identification and empirical strategy

The literature documents supporters of the incumbent government tend to be more optimistic about the economic outlook, whereas opposition supporters tend to be more pessimistic, a phenomenon described as partisan expectations by [Binder et al., 2024](#). Figure 4 provides supportive evidence of partisan inflation expectations in Turkey: supporters of the incumbent party (AKP) and its coalition partner (MHP) report the lowest inflation expectations, whereas supporters of the main opposition party (CHP) and other opposition parties report significantly higher expectations.

Our focus is on the role of media in shaping these partisan expectations. Figure 5 sheds further light on this issue by disaggregating inflation expectations along two dimensions: political alignment (AKP voters versus non-AKP voters) and the type of prime-time news channel watched (pro-government, pro-opposition, or neutral). Among AKP supporters, those who watch pro-government channels report the lowest inflation expectations, whereas those who watch pro-opposition channels report the highest. A similar but mirror-image pattern emerges among non-AKP voters.¹⁷

While these patterns are suggestive of a role for media in shaping inflation expectations after controlling for political alignment, Figure 5 is not conclusive. The patterns may simply reflect different extents of partisanship: AKP voters who watch pro-government channels may be more committed partisans with more optimistic priors, whereas those who watch neutral or opposition channels may hold weaker partisan ties, and vice versa for non-AKP voters.

To identify the *causal* impact of media coverage on inflation expectations, we develop an identification strategy that addresses the potential endogeneity between households' inflation expectations and their preferred television channels. The central concern in cross-sectional analyses is reverse causality: individuals may not form their views through media exposure, but instead selectively consume channels whose narratives reinforce beliefs they already hold—beliefs likely shaped, in the first place, by their underlying political ideology.

To mitigate such static selection concerns, we exploit the panel dimension of the dataset and focus on within-individual variation in exposure to inflation coverage over time. Figure 6 illustrates the intuition. Consider two individuals: Person A watches XTV, an opposition-leaning channel with extensive inflation coverage, and holds relatively high inflation expectations; Person B watches YTV, a government-friendly channel with limited inflation coverage, and holds relatively low inflation expectations. These viewing choices likely reflect underlying political preferences, which may themselves be correlated with baseline optimism or

¹⁷Figure D3 shows that the same patterns hold when we instead focus on the presidential alliance (AKP+MHP) vs. other party voters.

pessimism and, hence, with baseline inflation expectations (panel (a)). Our identification strategy therefore examines how each individual’s inflation expectations evolve *over time* in response to changes in the intensity of inflation coverage on their preferred channel. If, for instance, inflation coverage on XTV declines, we would expect Person A’s inflation expectations to decline accordingly—after controlling for ideological predispositions. Analogous reasoning applies to Person B: a rise in inflation coverage on YTV should lead to an increase in that individual’s inflation expectations (panel (b)).

A remaining concern is that individuals may switch television channels over time as their inflation expectations evolve. Although the survey evidence suggests that such switching is rare at a monthly frequency, we further address this potential source of dynamic selection by anchoring each individual’s channel assignment to their first observed response in the survey. This fixing ensures that channel choice remains constant throughout the analysis, removing any time variation that could confound identification.¹⁸

We thus estimate the following baseline model:

$$\mathbb{E} \pi_{i,c,v,p,t} = \beta_1 InfMention_{c,t-1} + \beta_2 X_{i,t} + \beta_3 \Omega_i + \beta_4 \lambda_{v,t} + \beta_5 \mu_{p,t} + \varepsilon_{i,c,v,p,t} \quad (1)$$

where the inflation expectations of household i , who watches channel c , resides in province v , and is politically aligned with party p in month t , are regressed on the average number of times inflation is mentioned on that channel in the previous month, $InfMention_{c,t-1}$. The specification also includes a vector of individual control variables $X_{i,t}$, individual fixed effects Ω_i , and province-by-time and party-by-time fixed effects, $\lambda_{v,t}$ and $\mu_{p,t}$, respectively. Table D1 provides the descriptive statistics of the control variables in the regression.

3.5. Results from the panel data

Baseline results. Table 2 reports the panel regression estimates. Across all specifications, we find a positive and statistically significant relationship between the frequency of inflation mentions on prime-time television news and household inflation expectations. The specification in column (1) shows that greater inflation coverage on TV in the previous month is associated with higher expected inflation, and this result is robust to the inclusion of a rich set of controls and fixed effects. Specifically, we control for time-varying individual characteristics such as age, marital status, and income group, as well as individual fixed effects that absorb time-invariant household heterogeneity. We further introduce increasingly demanding fixed effects, including party-by-time and province-by-time fixed effects, which account for

¹⁸We provide robustness checks regarding this approach further below.

partisan differences in expectations and local economic conditions that may shape inflation beliefs. Although the estimated coefficient attenuates as we introduce additional controls and fixed effects, the relationship remains statistically significant throughout.¹⁹

The magnitude of the effect is economically meaningful. In the most conservative baseline specification in column (6), a one standard deviation rise in *Inflation Mentions on TV* increases *Inflation Expectations* by approximately 10 per cent of its standard deviation. This finding suggests that more intensive media coverage of inflation has an impact on households' subjective inflation outlook. More broadly, the findings are consistent with models of information frictions in expectations formation, where households update their beliefs not only through personal price exposure but also through information transmitted by the media and other public sources (Carroll, 2003; Coibion and Gorodnichenko, 2015; D'Acunto et al., 2021).

Coverage vs. sentiment. Table 3 augments the baseline specification with the inflation-related optimism measure illustrated in Figure 3. The coefficient on inflation-related optimism on TV is negative and significant in columns (1) and (2), suggesting that, conditional on coverage volume, more optimistic framing of inflation in TV news is associated with lower inflation expectations, consistent with the notion that favorable media tone can move expectations downward. Nevertheless, in more saturated specifications, a horse race between the frequency of inflation mentions and the sentiment with which inflation is covered reveals that it is the former that shapes the results.²⁰ This asymmetry may help explain why pro-government channels are more reluctant to bring inflation into focus: once a negative macroeconomic concept is mentioned, optimistic reassurances about disinflation appear to have little offsetting effect on household inflation expectations, possibly given that mentioning inflation cues the memory of bad times (Gennaioli, Leva, Schoenle, and Shleifer, 2024; Braggion et al., 2024; Salle, Gorodnichenko, and Coibion, 2024).²¹

Taken together, the results point to a robust positive effect of inflation coverage on household inflation expectations, consistent with the news selection mechanism of Nimark and Pitschner (2019), whereas the role of media tone is more nuanced and sensitive to the exploited variation. The stability of the main coverage effect across all six specifications suggests prime-time TV news serves as a meaningful channel through which inflation infor-

¹⁹Results are similar when we estimate the different specifications on a common sample (see Table D3).

²⁰This conclusion still holds when we compute optimism (or sentiment) scores via alternative language models (See Table D4).

²¹In Table D5, we interact these terms to test whether they may have a joint impact on inflation expectations. While the unconditional relationship in column (1) is significantly negative, the interaction term loses statistical significance in columns (5) and (6) as Party $\times$ Time and Province $\times$ Time fixed effects absorb the relevant variation, suggesting that part of the effect reflects political and regional time-varying heterogeneity.

mation is transmitted to households.

Future expectations vs. past perceptions. Table 4 reproduces the last three columns of Table 2 for reference and adds three additional specifications in which the dependent variable is replaced by the perceived inflation over the past 12 months. Comparing columns (1)–(3) with columns (4)–(6), which include identical sets of controls and fixed effects, we find that perceived past inflation is not meaningfully affected by the frequency of inflation mentions on television in the previous month. Inflation expectations, by contrast, are strongly and positively related to television coverage.

This asymmetry is informative about the mechanism through which media shapes inflation beliefs. As shown in Figure A1, respondents in KUHIES cite their own purchases of goods and services as the most important source of inflation-related information (54%), followed by television and radio (29%). The fact that television ranks as the second most frequently cited source validates the relevance of the media channel we study, yet its influence operates primarily through the expectations channel rather than through perceptions. This pattern is consistent with the view that backward-looking perceptions of inflation are anchored in direct personal exposure, where households have a strong private signal from their own shopping baskets, whereas forward-looking expectations involve greater uncertainty and therefore leave more room for public signals, including media coverage, to influence belief formation. In other words, media matters most precisely where personal experience provides the least direct guidance (Carroll, 2003; Coibion and Gorodnichenko, 2015).

The absence of a relationship between television coverage and perceived past inflation also helps address a potential endogeneity concern. One might worry that television channels endogenously adjust the intensity of their inflation coverage in response to the inflation experiences of their viewers, in order to cater to audience demand and maintain ratings. If this were the case, perceived past inflation would be positively correlated with the frequency of inflation mentions on television. The lack of such a relationship suggests that coverage intensity is unlikely to be driven by viewers’ recent inflation experiences.

A related but distinct concern is that channels may adjust their inflation coverage in line with their alignment of a certain political party. For instance, during periods of heightened polarization, politically-charged channels may intensify their inflation coverage as part of a broader editorial stance, rather than in response to actual economic conditions. If the survey respondents similarly (but independently) follow their affiliated party when forming their inflation expectations, this may induce spurious correlation in our setting. We address this form of endogeneity by including *party* $\times$ *time* fixed effects, which absorb any time-varying heterogeneity in inflation expectations across respondents of different party affiliations.

To further corroborate these findings, Table 5 augments the baseline specification by including perceived past inflation as an additional control variable. As expected, inflation expectations are strongly correlated with perceived inflation, reflecting the important role of households’ own price experiences in shaping their forward-looking beliefs (Weber, d’Acunto, Gorodnichenko, and Coibion, 2022a; Weber, Gorodnichenko, and Coibion, 2022b). Crucially, however, the coefficient on inflation mentions remains statistically significant even after controlling for perceived inflation and including the full set of individual controls, individual fixed effects, and both party-by-time and province-by-time fixed effects. Because the media effect survives this demanding specification, it cannot be attributed simply to television news echoing what households already know from their own price experiences, but rather reflects genuinely new information that shifts forward-looking beliefs beyond what is already captured by households’ perceived inflation.²²

Instrumental variable strategy. Figure 1 shows that inflation coverage over time changes in tandem with local elections especially for neutral and pro-opposition TV channels that normally talk more about inflation. In line with the previous literature showing that pre-determined events can create news pressure on media and reduce other types of coverage (see Durante and Zhuravskaya, 2018), we exploit these election-induced changes in order to generate quasi-random variation in our main variable of interest (i.e., inflation mentions) and –in return– to test its casual impact on inflation expectations.²³

While our estimations control for election coverage on TV, it is important to note that we do not consider the media to be the only channel through which elections can affect inflation expectations. Previous literature has demonstrated that local elections can create credit cycles that may shape real economic outcomes (Cole, 2009; Englmaier and Stowasser, 2017) although the effects are usually local, heterogeneous and may not add up at country level (Bircan and Saka, 2021). If such channels were nonetheless to influence the aggregate inflation in the country, our instrument would fail the exclusion restriction: both media coverage and household expectations might be driven by the underlying changes in inflation dynamics. To mitigate this concern, we directly control for the rate of CPI inflation (at the country-level) as well as perceived past inflation (at the individual-level).

We report the results in Table 6. Our instrument, which is measured as the distance

²²In Table D6, we collapse our dataset at channel x month level in order to test whether inflation perceptions of the viewers of a specific channel might affect that channel’s inflation coverage next month. We find no evidence of such a “catering channel” once the cross-sectional selection of viewers to channels is controlled via channel fixed effects in columns 3 and 4.

²³Local elections in Turkey occur every 5 years and their timing is pre-determined as it is specified in the country’s constitution. A snap local election would require a constitutional change and has never taken place in country’s political history (see Bircan and Saka, 2021).

in months to the local election in March, 2024, varies only over time which restricts our empirical specifications to those without time fixed effects. The first-stage (shown in column 2) confirms the relevance of our instrument as the F -statistics are considerably above the Stock-Yogo threshold of 10. As expected, inflation coverage on TV drops in months closer to the election. The second stage shows this quasi-random drop in inflation coverage on TV reduces inflation expectations closer to election months. The most conservative estimate is larger than the least conservative estimate in our baseline Table 2. We repeat the exercise in Table D7 by additionally controlling for perceived past inflation at the individual level and find qualitatively similar results.²⁴

Political alignment of TV channels vs. viewers. Table 7 examines heterogeneity across viewers of different television channels. The table reports coefficients on the interaction between inflation mentions on television and the respondent’s preferred channel category. The results indicate that viewers of neutral channels are driving the baseline effect. The coefficient on the neutral channel interaction is significant at the one percent level across all six specifications, and the magnitude remains quite stable as we introduce increasingly demanding fixed effects, including province-by-time and party-by-time interactions. By contrast, the coefficient on the pro-government channel interaction is positive but never reaches statistical significance, whereas the pro-opposition channel interaction is close to zero throughout, with only a single marginally significant estimate in column (3).

To put the magnitudes in perspective, the coefficient estimates for the neutral channel interaction range from approximately 4.6 to 5.5 (columns 1 through 3). This magnitude implies that, for the viewer of a neutral channel, a one standard deviation rise in *Inflation Mentions on TV* increases *Inflation Expectations* by at least 31 per cent of its standard deviation.

The near-zero effect for opposition channels is notable. One plausible explanation is a saturation effect: opposition channels discuss inflation so heavily and persistently (see Figure 1) that marginal variation in the number of mentions does little to change the inflation outlook of their viewers. Another possibility is that opposition-channel inflation coverage is perceived as politically motivated rather than purely informational, which may reduce its

²⁴A caveat of our IV strategy is that local elections might create other channels that may work not through realized inflation but by directly changing people’s expectations about future macroeconomic fundamentals due to political developments such as promises of future policy changes, etc. To further test whether media is the primary channel in our setting through which elections shape inflation expectations, we also run reduced-form regressions in Table D8 for two separate samples: those who prefer to watch TV for news and those who don’t. We are unable to run IV regressions for the second sample as these are individuals without channel choices and thus were dropped in our previous analyses. Results are consistent with the argument that media exposure is key in driving the drop in inflation expectations around elections.

persuasive impact on expectations.

The last three columns of the table (columns 4 through 6) convert the dependent variable into a binary indicator that takes the value of one if the household’s inflation expectation is above the sample median. This specification is akin to a linear probability model and helps mitigate the influence of outliers in reported expectations. The results remain robust under this alternative specification with the corresponding coefficients range from approximately 3.1 to 4.0, indicating that one additional inflation mention on average raises the probability of reporting above-median inflation expectations by more than 3 times.

Table 8 further examines these results by incorporating respondents’ voting preferences in the 2023 general elections. The estimates reveal a notable heterogeneity: individuals who voted for the governing party, AKP, exhibit a substantially stronger response to inflation-related content on neutral channels, with coefficients roughly twice as large as those for non-AKP voters. In the continuous specification, the coefficients for AKP voters watching neutral channels range from approximately 7.8 to 8.6, implying that a one standard deviation change in inflation coverage on a neutral channel leads to an increase of more than 50% of standard deviation of inflation expectations.

This differential response could be consistent with a Bayesian updating interpretation. Although AKP voters in this group already watch neutral channels, the rest of their information environment, including party messaging, social circles, and casual exposure to pro-government media, likely tilts toward downplaying inflation. As a result, the inflation coverage they receive from their preferred neutral channel carries relatively more weight in their overall belief formation, generating larger expectation revisions. Non-AKP voters, by contrast, inhabit a broader information ecosystem that is already more aligned with inflation narratives, so the marginal informational contribution of neutral television is comparatively smaller.²⁵

It is also worth noting that the pro-government channel interaction with AKP voters is significant in column (1) but loses significance as we introduce province-by-time and party-by-time fixed effects. This pattern suggests that the significant coefficient partially at least captures spatially or politically correlated confounds rather than reflecting a genuine causal channel, a pattern that strengthens confidence in the identification strategy.

Importantly, viewers of neutral channels respond to inflation mentions regardless of their political affiliation. Although AKP voters exhibit a stronger response, the overall pattern suggests that it is the informational content of neutral channels, possibly paired with weaker

²⁵This is also consistent with the possibility of the lack of time variation in inflation coverage of pro-government channels making the statistical inference difficult in Table 7. In line with this interpretation, our RCT in the next section detects a statistically significant reaction by pro-government TV viewers when their exposure to inflation coverage is experimentally varied.

priors for consumers that select into neutral TV channels, rather than partisan alignment between viewers and political actors, that primarily drives the observed changes in inflation expectations. Partisan alignment can still play a role in that it determines the endogenous selection of viewers into different channels. Supporters of the government and the opposition have on the one hand a higher likelihood to select into channels that align with their views but likely also have already stronger views on the economy, that is, tighter priors. As a result, they are less responsive to news about inflation in either direction; yet, the content of the news is likely also more similar to their priors, that is, the TV coverage is less “news” to politically-aligned watchers, and as a result, they react less. AKP voters who select into watching neutral channels likely have weaker priors, which is why they do not watch pro-government channels to begin with.

Two mechanisms may explain the stronger response among viewers of neutral channels. First, these viewers may hold weaker prior beliefs about inflation and therefore be more receptive to new information. Second, they may place greater trust in the news source compared to viewers of channels that are more strongly aligned with political partisanship. In the following section, we explore these mechanisms using our randomized controlled trial embedded in a customized survey. The experimental evidence suggests that viewers of neutral channels are less politically polarized and respond to inflation-related news regardless of whether it originates from their preferred channel. We return to this interpretation in the next section.

3.6. *Robustness Checks*

The Appendix reports a series of robustness checks confirming the stability of our main results. First, we conduct placebo tests in Table D9 with other economic terms mentioned on prime-time TV news that may not be directly related to inflation discussions and show that none of them can results in statistically significant effects with stricter set of fixed effects. Second, Table D10 shows the estimates remain qualitatively unchanged when we remove sample weights. Third, Table D11 demonstrates our baseline results are robust to alternative procedures for removing outliers. Fourth, different ways of clustering standard errors do not qualitatively change our statistical inference as documented in Table D12.²⁶

²⁶Because conventional cluster-robust inference is unreliable with few clusters at channel (13 clusters) and party (10 clusters) levels, we additionally conduct inference using the wild cluster bootstrap procedure (Cameron, Gelbach, and Miller, 2008). Following MacKinnon and Webb (2018), we employ the six-point Webb distribution, which substantially expands the set of possible bootstrap samples and has been shown to perform better in small-cluster settings, particularly when cluster sizes are heterogeneous. The bootstrap p-values reported in Table D13 confirm that our main coefficient of interest remains statistically significant at conventional levels.

We also examine the sensitivity of the estimates to alternative sample restrictions. Our baseline specification includes individuals with at least five survey observations. Table D14 shows the results are robust to alternative minimum participation thresholds.

Next, Table D15 tests the robustness of the inflation mentions index to different transcript collection frequencies. Specifically, we compare our baseline measure based on daily channel transcripts with alternative constructions that require a minimum of 10 or 5 transcripts within a given month.

An important feature of our empirical design is that we assign each respondent to a channel category based on the preferred news channel they report upon first entering the survey, and we maintain this assignment throughout the panel. This approach yields an intent-to-treat estimate, since some respondents may change their viewing habits over the course of the sample period. To the extent that such switching occurs, the mismatch between assigned and actual media exposure introduces classical measurement error, attenuating the estimated coefficients toward zero. Our estimates should therefore be interpreted as a lower bound of the true causal effect of media exposure on inflation expectations. Crucially, however, this design choice carries an important identification advantage: by fixing channel assignment at baseline, we avoid the endogeneity that would arise if channel choice were allowed to vary contemporaneously with inflation expectations. If individuals with evolving inflation beliefs sort into channels that confirm their priors, for instance by switching away from channels that present unwelcome inflation coverage, a time-varying assignment would conflate the causal effect of media exposure with selective sorting. Our fixed assignment ensures that the estimated relationship reflects the informational impact of media coverage rather than the endogenous matching of viewers to channels.

A potential limitation of this approach is that if channel switching is sufficiently widespread, a large share of observations would effectively be matched to channels that respondents no longer watch, and the estimates may become difficult to interpret as a meaningful media effect. In practice, channel switching in our sample is limited: the vast majority of respondents report the same preferred news channel across survey waves. Nevertheless, we check how our results would change if we correctly matched each individual to their reported preferred channel in each month. Tables D16 and Table D17 present the results with alternative ways of allocating individuals to TV channels and dropping frequent channel switchers from our sample.²⁷ The estimates are very similar to those obtained under the fixed baseline assignment, which is reassuring on two fronts: it confirms that the degree of channel switching in our data is not sufficiently prevalent to materially affect the baseline estimates, and

²⁷The frequent channel switcher is defined as an individual whose most frequently preferred channel over our sample period has been preferred less than 50% of the time.

it indicates that endogenous sorting into channels does not appear to be a quantitatively important source of bias in the time-varying specification either.

4. Exploring the Mechanisms via an RCT

To investigate the mechanisms underlying our panel results, we implemented an information provision experiment embedded in a customized survey. In this pre-registered survey experiment, which is conducted independently of the regular monthly KUHIES survey, more than 8,000 respondents are randomly assigned to information treatments that vary the tone of the inflation-related media slant and its perceived source, allowing us to identify the causal impact of these different exposures on inflation expectations.²⁸ Importantly, we abstain from providing quantitative information on inflation (such as official inflation estimates from the central bank) to make sure such information, whose effectiveness has been shown in the previous literature, would not drive respondents’ updating of their priors.

The survey additionally collects detailed information on respondents’ demographics characteristics, media preferences for prime-time television news, policy and political preferences, and planned spending and saving decisions.²⁹

4.1. *Experimental design and empirical strategy*

After answering a question on their preferred TV channel for news, a set of baseline demographic questions and a question that asks their 12-month-ahead inflation expectations (i.e., prior), each household is randomly assigned to one of eight groups of approximately 1,000 respondents. One group serves as a pure control group and another as a placebo treatment group. The treated groups are provided with the following statement:

“Below we present you with a sample news article compiled from TV news bulletins broadcast last month:”

²⁸The experimental design was approved by the Institutional Review Board at Koç University (2025.277.IRB3.104) and was registered at the AER RCT Registry (#AEARCTR-0017085).

²⁹The survey was conducted by Veri Enstitüsü (<https://verenstitusu.com/>), one of the leading market research firms in Turkey. The sample was constructed using stratification based on Address-Based Population Registration System (ADNKS) data on neighborhood and village population sizes and education levels, combined with neighborhood- and village-level results from the 14 May 2023 General Election. Settlements were first categorized as rural, urban, or metropolitan, and then stratified across 12 regions to determine the sampling frame. To ensure representativeness of Turkey’s adult population, weighting factors were applied using distributions of gender, age, education, and 2023 General Election vote choice. Quotas were applied by age, gender, education, and NUTS-1 regional distribution. After fieldwork, data are weighted by age, gender, education, and 2023 vote choice.

Afterwards, the respondents assigned to the positive treatment group are presented with the following text:

Inflation Down, Hopes Up

“September inflation figures were announced, and once again public attention turned to achieving lasting price stability. The economic administration emphasizes its commitment to a determined disinflation program and highlights recent progress, saying that better days are near. Officials state that inflation has been steadily declining over the past year and that in May, annual inflation dropped to its lowest level in three and a half years. They also stress that, even at the cost of political sacrifice, they have avoided populist steps that would burden society, choosing instead to implement a reform program that strengthens the structural resilience of the economy. *As officials put it: “We are determined in our fight against inflation, and we will not stray from the path of stability.”*

The negative treatment group is presented with the following text:

Every Morning, a More Expensive Life

“September inflation figures were announced, and once again public attention turned to price increases. For many households, each newly announced figure means waking up to a more expensive life and confirmation of shrinking purchasing power—an indication that the coming days will be more difficult. In recent months, inflation has become the most frequently mentioned word in everyone’s daily conversations. Although officials keep saying that inflation will decline, citizens are being crushed under rising costs and are waking up almost every morning to new price hikes. *As one young person summed it up in a street interview: “The situation is unbearable; even dreams are nothing but dreams anymore.”*

The placebo group receives the following text:

Rethinking Tooth Care

“A new study has pointed to an unusual source of hope for healthier teeth: keratin, the natural protein found in human hair and sheep’s wool. Researchers say keratin can coat teeth and help repair damaged enamel, which may one day mean fewer cavities and stronger smiles. For now, keratin is not part of any toothpaste or mouthwash people can buy, but scientists are planning further tests to see how it works best. The discovery has sparked curiosity and excitement—showing that

even everyday materials could open the door to surprising improvements in dental care.”

We designed the treatments with several considerations in mind. First, the positive and negative treatment texts are deliberately constructed to be identical in length and structural format, differing only in their editorial spin, so that any differential response can be attributed to tone rather than to the amount of information provided. Both texts open with the same factual anchor, the announcement of September inflation figures, and then diverge in framing: the positive treatment emphasizes institutional commitment and recent progress, whereas the negative treatment emphasizes household hardship and eroding purchasing power. Each text closes with a direct quote to mimic the stylistic conventions of actual TV news reporting and to equalize the rhetorical intensity across arms. Second, the placebo text is constructed according to the same criteria. It is designed to be entirely unrelated to inflation or economic conditions, of similar length to the treatment texts, and to carry the same surface features of a news article, namely a headline, a narrative body, and a forward-looking closing sentence. The subject matter, a scientific finding about keratin and dental care, is deliberately mundane and politically neutral, ensuring that any difference between the placebo and treatment groups in posterior expectations reflects exposure to inflation-relevant content rather than the mere act of reading a news item.

In addition to varying the tone of the media slant (positive vs. negative), we also examine whether the perceived source of the narrative influences respondents’ reactions. To this end, we construct additional treatment groups in which the same narratives are presented together with the logo of a specific television channel. The channels are selected to represent three categories in the Turkish media landscape: pro-government, pro-opposition, and politically neutral, consistent with the color coded groupings introduced in Figure 1.

Respondents assigned to the *Pro-Government Channel* treatment are shown the positive narrative accompanied by the logo of one of the two pro-government networks, ATV or TRT (randomly-assigned within this treatment group). This pairing reflects the typical media environment in which pro-government channels tend to present more optimistic narratives about inflation.

Respondents in the *Pro-Opposition Channel* treatment are shown the negative narrative together with the logo of one of the opposition-leaning networks, Sözcü TV or Halk TV (randomly-assigned within this treatment group), reflecting the more critical framing of inflation commonly observed in these outlets.

Finally, respondents in the *Neutral Channel* treatments are shown both the positive and negative narratives paired with the logos of Habertürk or Kanal D (randomly-assigned within

this treatment group), which represent channels with a more neutral editorial stance.³⁰

The experimental design first measures respondents’ prior inflation expectations and then exposes them to curated inflation news treatments that vary both in tone (positive vs. negative) and in perceived source (either no source or pro-government, pro-opposition, and neutral channels). Respondents later express their posterior inflation expectations via a question that differs from the previous one in its format in order to minimize attrition in the survey and experimenter demand effects (see De Quidt, Haushofer, and Roth, 2018; Weber et al., 2025).

Table 1 reports in the lower panel the descriptive statistics for the RCT where the roughly equal means across treatment arms suggest successful randomization. Table E1 reports results from balance tests and supports random treatment assignment. The F-stat estimates indicate that the randomization was successful, as we do not detect any systematic differences in observable characteristics across treatment groups.³¹

4.2. Results from RCT

Baseline results. In this section, we characterize the average effects of media narrative treatments on respondents’ inflation expectations. Following Weber et al., 2025, we start by estimating the following baseline model:

$$\mathbb{E}_i^{Post} \pi_{t+1} = b_0 + b_1 \times E_i^{Prior} \pi_{t+1} + b_2 \times E_i^{Prior} \pi_{t+1} \times Treat_i + b_3 \times Treat_i + error_i \quad (2)$$

In the regression specification described above, we regress individuals’ posterior inflation expectations ($\mathbb{E}_i^{Post}$) on their prior expectations ($\mathbb{E}_i^{Prior}$), dummy variables indicating exposure to alternative signals, and the interaction between priors and the treatment indicators. The coefficient on each treatment dummy therefore captures the average effect of receiving that treatment on individual inflation expectations relative to the control group. To account for the presence of outliers and survey noise, all regressions are estimated using Huber-robust methods.

Under Bayesian updating, respondents are expected to place some weight on their prior beliefs and some weight on the signal they receive. In this framework, the weight placed on priors is captured by b_1 for the control group and by $b_1 + b_2$ for the treated groups, while

³⁰Altogether we have seven treatment groups: positive, positive with a pro-government channel logo, positive with a neutral channel logo, negative, negative with pro-opposition channel logo, negative with a neutral channel logo, and a placebo group that gets information about dental care.

³¹We also control for all of these individual characteristics in later robustness checks.

the weight placed on the signal is captured by b_3 . Bayesian updating implies a convergence of beliefs, that is, we expect b_2 to be negative because treated respondents should place less weight on their priors.

We illustrate the baseline results graphically in Figure 7, which reports results separately for four subsamples defined by respondents’ preferred source of prime-time television news. Panel (a) shows individuals who primarily watch pro-government channels, panel (b) those who watch politically neutral channels, and panel (c) those who watch pro-opposition channels. Panel (d) includes respondents who report not watching prime-time television news. For each treatment and the control group, the figure presents bin-scatter plots of respondents’ posterior inflation expectations (elicited immediately after the treatment) against their prior inflation expectations.

The slope of the relationship is less than one for the control group. This partly reflects the different wording of the inflation expectation questions used to elicit prior and posterior beliefs, as well as some degree of mean reversion in responses and survey noise. More importantly, the figure shows flatter slopes for the treatment groups who watch neutral channels (panel (b)), suggesting that individuals in these groups place less weight on their prior beliefs and instead incorporate the signals embedded in the media narratives they receive. The fact that the different treatment groups exhibit approximately similar slopes indicates that the various treatments influence expectations in a broadly similar manner. Occasional steeper slopes for the treatment groups in panels (a), (c), or (d) are neither statistically nor economically significant.

Table 9 reports the regression results. Each column presents estimates for the subsample indicated in the table. Consistent with Figure 7, we find that individuals in the treatment groups generally place significantly less weight on their prior beliefs compared to those in the control group. The results are strongest for viewers of neutral channels. For this group, both the positive and the negative treatments lead to a convergence in beliefs, regardless of the source of the information. This finding suggests that individuals who report watching neutral channels may hold weaker prior views or exhibit greater prior uncertainty. This pattern is consistent with these viewers being less polarized and more perceptive to information. While high and volatile inflation and weak central bank credibility generate prior uncertainty across all viewer groups, strongly partisan viewers may anchor their priors to politically motivated beliefs, dampening their updating. Neutral channel viewers, lacking such anchoring, translate that uncertainty into genuine responsiveness to new information regardless of its source.

Households who report watching pro-government channels also significantly revise their prior expectations, but only when the signal originates from pro-government channels, consistent with them placing greater trust in the source of the information (Weber et al., 2025). By

contrast, individuals who report watching opposition channels, as well as those who do not follow television news, do not exhibit statistically significant revisions in their expectations. Given the high frequency of inflation coverage on pro-opposition channels, as illustrated in Figure 1, these viewers likely hold stronger and more entrenched prior beliefs and place less weight on any new signal regardless of its source.

The main effects of the treatment dummies are positive and significant across all treatment arms for neutral channel viewers (column 3), indicating that inflation-related coverage leads to an upward revision in posterior expectations for this group. This reinforces our panel findings that inflation coverage, regardless of its tone or source, tends to push expectations upward, particularly among viewers with weaker prior beliefs.³²

A previous pilot experiment. As a robustness check, we present results from an alternative experiment in Table E4.³³ Unlike the baseline RCT, this preceding experiment provides respondents with the point estimate of headline inflation alongside the same media narratives, effectively combining two treatments. Despite the smaller sample size, the findings are consistent with the baseline. The coefficient estimates associated with prior revisions are noticeably larger, consistent with respondents’ exposure to the actual inflation figure. In both RCTs, the results are strongest for viewers of neutral channels.

Policy and political preferences. We next focus on estimating the causal impact of rising inflation expectations on respondents’ policy and political preferences for the sample of neutral-channel viewers. For this purpose, we follow Coibion, Georgarakos, Gorodnichenko, and Van Rooij (2023): we group all inflation-related treatments under one group (since they do not significantly differ from each other) and then instrument respondents’ inflation expectations by using this aggregated treatment indicator and its interaction with prior expectations.³⁴ Hence, we exploit the experimentally generated variation in inflation expectations to identify their *causal* impact on various outcomes. In particular, we have four post-treatment questions in the RCT that measure respondents’ policy and political preferences in a binary format.³⁵

³²Controlling for individual-level characteristics (listed in Table E2) does not change any of our interpretations as can be seen in Table E3.

³³Related to the pilot experiment, the summary statistics (see Table E5), balance tests (see Table E6) and robustness checks with individual controls (see Table E7) can all be found in the Online Appendix.

³⁴We drop the placebo group from this analysis as Table 9 shows its updating of inflation expectations does not meaningfully differ from that of the control group.

³⁵These are *Believes in heterodox policy*, which indicates if the respondent believes that “lower interest rates are needed to curb high inflation”; *Distrusts in gov’t policies*, which indicates whether the respondent has no trust at all in government’s economic policies; *Votes for AKP*, which indicates if the respondent would vote for the incumbent government party if an election was to take place on the day of the survey; and finally

Table 10 documents the results. As the first-stage relationship is not very strong in our setting, we also report weak-IV p-values and upper/lower bounds for each estimate. In response to rising inflation expectations induced by our treatments, neutral-channel viewers reduce their likelihood of believing in heterodox monetary policies (columns 1-2) and become more likely to distrust government’s economic policies (columns 3-4) although none of these estimates are estimated with sufficient precision. On the political front, higher inflation expectations lower the probability of voting for the incumbent party or donating to its supporters.³⁶ In particular, a one pp increase in inflation expectations lowers the probability of voting for the incumbent party by nearly 5 percent for neutral-channel viewers. Even under the conservative assumption of null effects for politically-aligned audiences and those not watching news on TV, this would translate into a drop of 85 basis points in the overall vote share of the incumbent party for every one pp rise in inflation expectations.³⁷

These results possibly explain why pro-government (pro-opposition) channels aim to minimize (maximize) inflation coverage in their news, as we had illustrated in Figure 1. Both types of channels aim to improve the electoral chances of the political parties that they are associated with and in the process bias their inflation coverage and tone. This bias further distorts the inflation-related news consumption across households as they generally watch the TV channels that are aligned with their political affiliations, resulting in a polarized society living in the same macroeconomic environment but having systematically different inflation outlooks for the near future.

5. Conclusion

This paper studies how prime-time television news shapes household inflation expectations in a high-inflation and politically polarized environment. Using Turkey as a case study, we combine a monthly household panel survey with channel-level measures of inflation coverage and inflation-related sentiment constructed from television transcripts. We then complement the panel evidence with a pre-registered information experiment that varies inflation-related narratives and the television source to which these narratives are attributed. Together, the two designs allow us to study both the relationship between actual media coverage and household expectations, and the mechanisms through which politically segmented audiences

Donates more to AKP, which indicates if the respondent would split a hypothetical donation more in favor of an AKP voter than a non-AKP voter.

³⁶We ask the donation question as an alternative to voting in case respondents may be uncomfortable in revealing their true voting preferences in an authoritarian country such as Turkey.

³⁷Since neutral-channel viewers are approximately 17% of the sample, a back of the envelope estimate is simply $5\% \times 17\% = 0.85\%$.

update their beliefs.

The panel evidence shows that greater inflation coverage on a respondent’s initially preferred television channel predicts higher inflation expectations. This relationship is robust to individual fixed effects, controls for respondents’ past inflation perceptions, and demanding party-by-time and province-by-time fixed effects. The evidence is therefore difficult to explain solely by static sorting into media outlets, partisan shifts in beliefs, or local economic shocks. At the same time, the analysis highlights that the average relationship masks substantial heterogeneity across audiences. The response is concentrated among viewers of politically neutral channels, whereas viewers of pro-government and pro-opposition channels display much weaker responses to changes in inflation coverage. Moreover, the frequency of inflation mentions is more robustly related to expectations than the optimism or pessimism with which inflation is discussed. This pattern is consistent with the idea that media coverage affects expectations partly by making inflation salient, independent of the precise tone of the coverage.

The experimental evidence clarifies the mechanisms behind this heterogeneity. Viewers of politically neutral channels update their inflation expectations in response to inflation-related narratives regardless of tone or source attribution. This finding suggests that the strong panel response among these viewers reflects weaker prior anchoring or greater openness to new economic information, rather than a unique trust in neutral media outlets. By contrast, viewers of pro-government channels update primarily when information is attributed to a pro-government source, consistent with an important role for politically aligned source credibility. Viewers of pro-opposition channels do not systematically update in response to the treatments, a pattern consistent with precise priors or saturation in an information environment in which inflation is already highly salient.

Taken together, the findings show that media segmentation shapes both the supply of economic information and the way households process that information. In polarized media environments, inflation coverage does not necessarily operate as a common public signal. Instead, the same macroeconomic environment can generate different belief dynamics across audiences because outlets differ in how often they discuss inflation and because viewers differ in their willingness to update in response to new information. The results therefore point to a channel through which political polarization can weaken the common information base underlying aggregate expectation formation.

These findings have implications for monetary-policy communication and expectation anchoring. When inflation is high and expectations are weakly anchored, households may place substantial weight on intermediated information. Yet in a politically segmented media environment, the effectiveness of communication depends not only on the content of

the message but also on the perceived credibility of the source and the prior beliefs of the audience. Policymakers seeking to anchor expectations may therefore need to account for the informational environments through which households encounter economic news. Communication strategies that rely exclusively on official announcements may be less effective when trust is politically uneven and when households receive economic information through distinct media ecosystems.

The paper also connects expectation formation to broader political-economy outcomes. In the experimental analysis, increases in inflation expectations among viewers of neutral channels are associated with lower confidence in the government’s economic management and lower stated support for the incumbent government. Because these estimates rely on experimentally induced variation in expectations but a relatively weak first stage, we interpret them as suggestive evidence on political consequences rather than as the central contribution of the paper. They nevertheless illustrate why inflation expectations are politically consequential in high-inflation environments and why the media coverage of inflation may matter beyond its immediate effects on household forecasts.

More broadly, our results contribute to the literature on information frictions, media coverage, and economic belief formation by studying a setting in which inflation is both highly salient and politically contested. Most evidence on media and inflation expectations comes from advanced economies and from aggregate or print-based measures of news coverage. By linking individual expectations to the television channels respondents report watching, and by combining this panel evidence with an experiment that varies source attribution, we provide evidence on how media coverage affects expectations when the credibility of information is itself politically segmented.

Future research could extend this analysis in at least two directions. First, richer measures of narrative content may help distinguish more sharply between topic selection, causal framing, and the emotional tone of inflation news. Second, as households increasingly obtain economic information from digital platforms and social media, it will be important to study whether similar mechanisms operate in more algorithmically mediated information environments. The central lesson of this paper is that the effect of economic news on expectations depends not only on what information is supplied, but also on who receives it, through which source, and against which prior beliefs it is interpreted.

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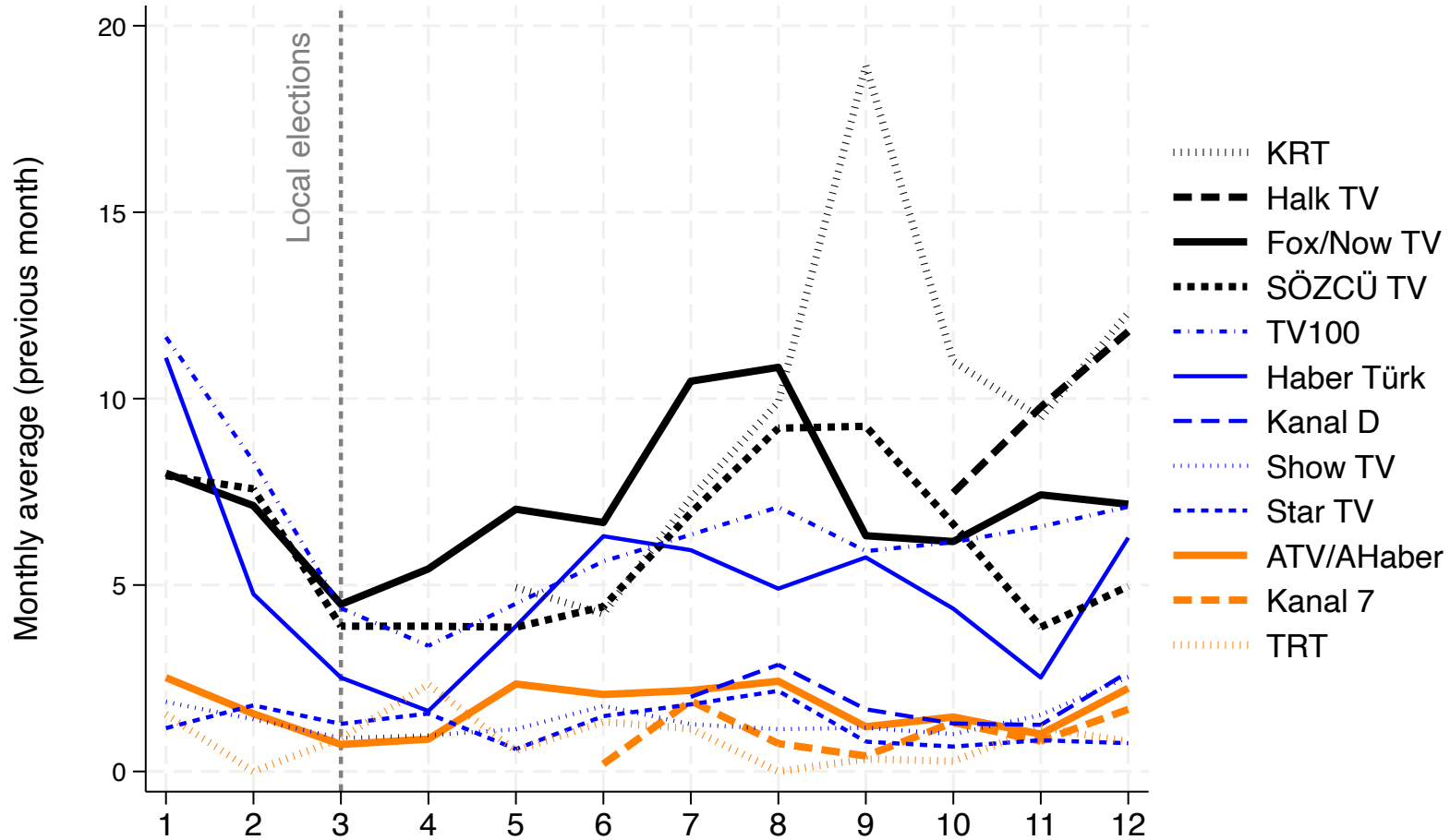


Fig. 1. **Number of Inflation Mentions in Prime-time TV News (2024m1 - 2024m12).** This figure shows the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Pro-government channels are colored in orange, neutral channels are colored in blue and pro-opposition channels are colored in black. Local elections took place on 31 March 2024. Source: Authors’ calculations based on publicly available data on YouTube & Dailymotion.

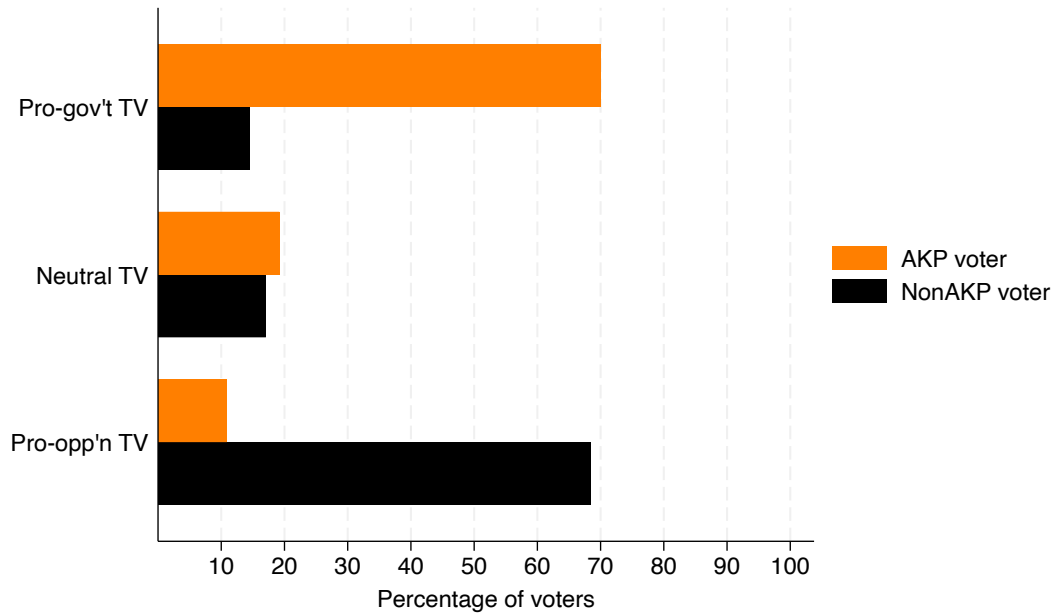


Fig. 2. **TV Viewership by 2023 Vote.** This figure shows the percentage of individuals in KUHIES who voted (or not) for the incumbent government party (i.e., AKP) during national elections in 2023 broken down by the same individuals' *ex ante* preferred TV channel for watching prime-time news. AKP voters are colored in orange and others are colored in black. National elections took place on 14 May 2023. Source: Authors' calculations based on KUHIES.

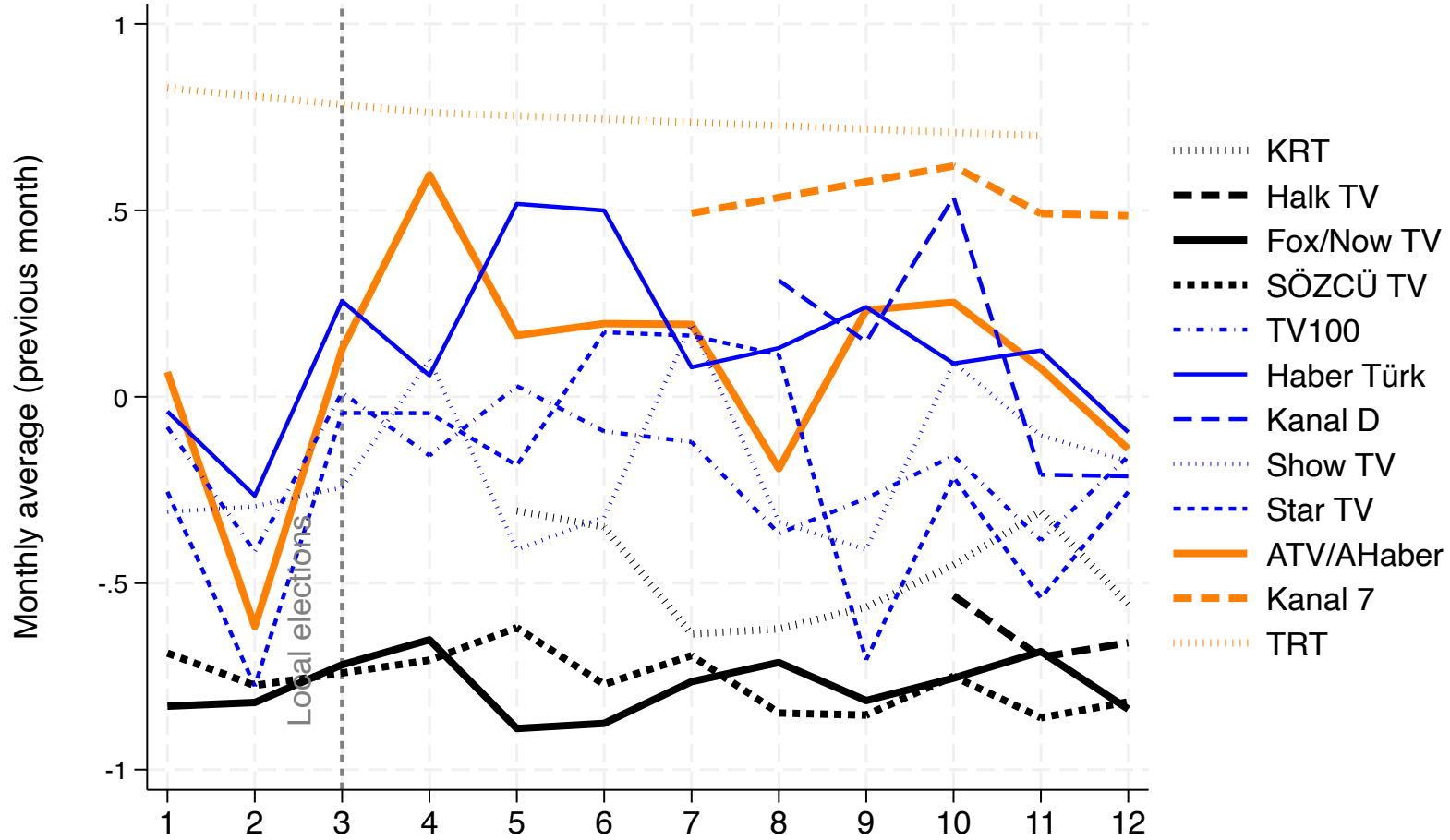


Fig. 3. **Inflation-related Optimism/Pessimism in Prime-time TV News (2024m1 - 2024m12).** This figure shows a measure of optimistic tone around “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Context window around the “inflation” keyword is extracted as ± 30 words. Inflation-related optimism is measured by a fine-tuned BERT model pre-trained on Turkish text (see [Online Appendix C](#) for details). Pro-government channels are colored in orange, neutral channels are colored in blue and pro-opposition channels are colored in black. Local elections took place on 31 March 2024. Source: Authors’ calculations based on publicly available data on YouTube & Dailymotion.

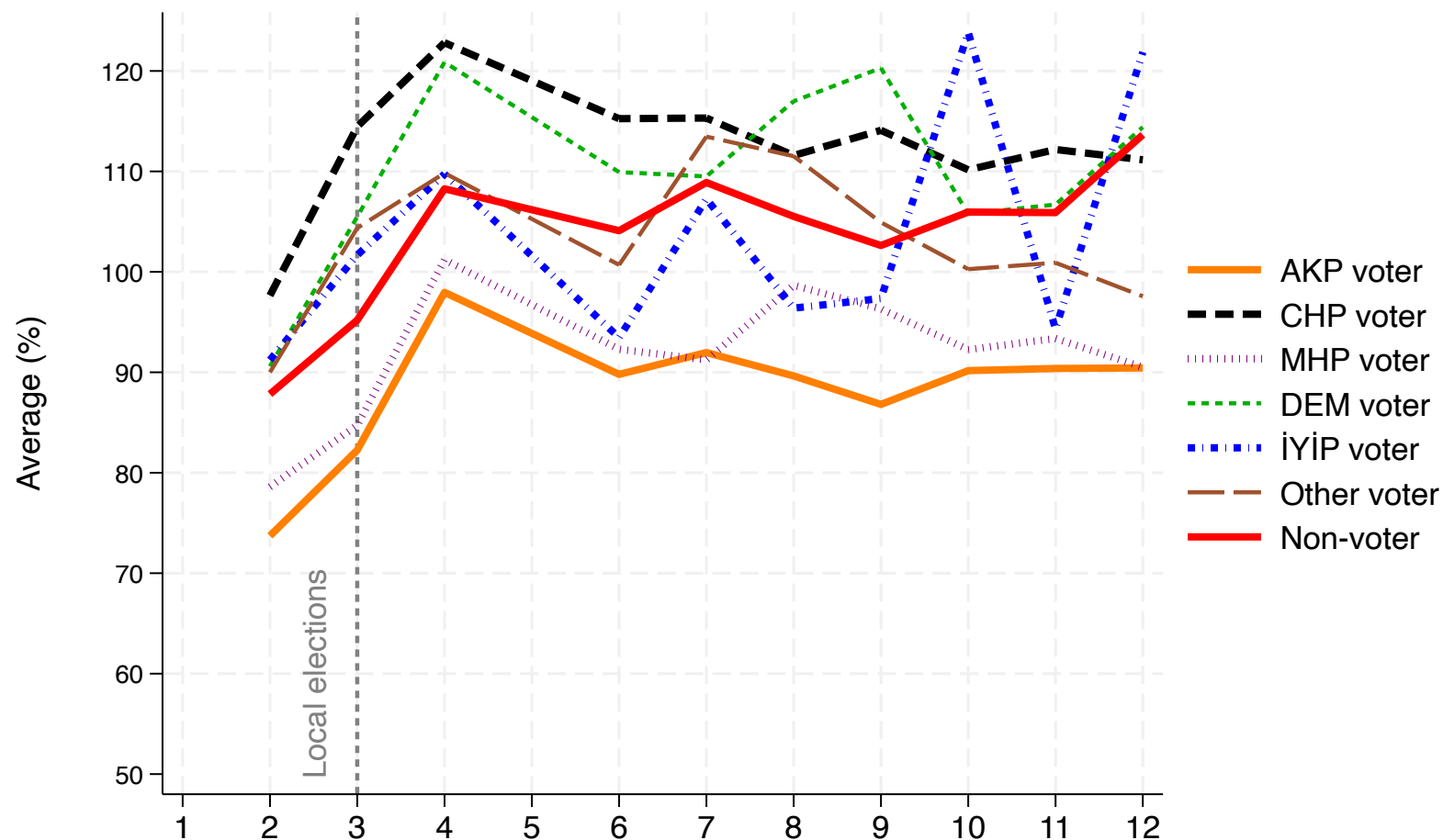


Fig. 4. **Household Inflation Expectations by 2023 Vote (2024m1 - 2024m12)**. This figure shows the average monthly inflation expectations broken down by the party that respondents voted for during 2023 national elections. Those who voted for the incumbent government party (i.e., AKP) are colored in orange. National elections took place on 14 May 2023. Source: Authors' calculations based on KUHIES.

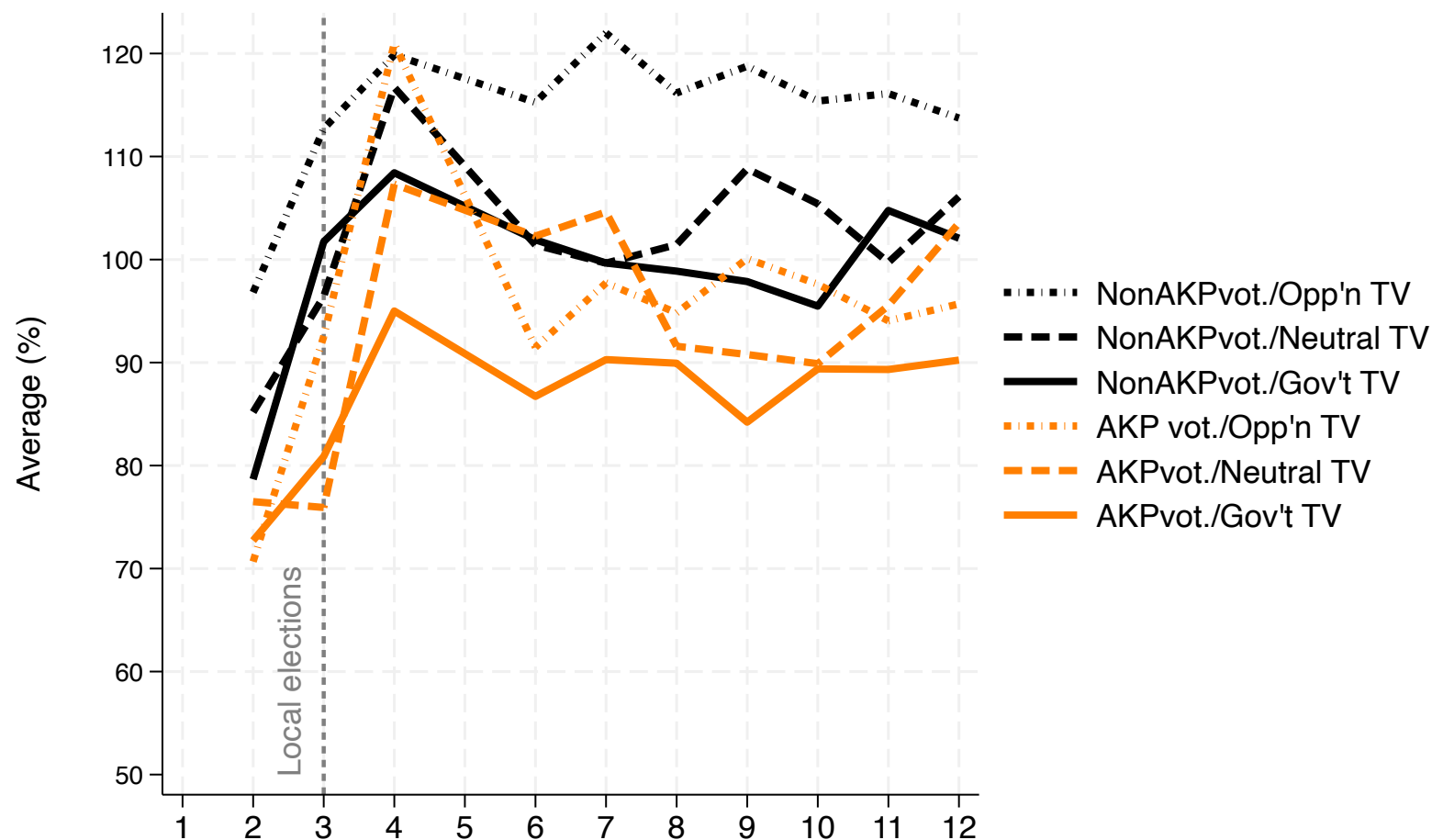


Fig. 5. **Household Inflation Expectations by 2023 Vote and *ex ante* TV Channel Preference (2024m1 - 2024m12).** This figure shows the average monthly inflation expectations broken down both by the government party (i.e., AKP) vs. non-government parties that respondents voted for during 2023 national elections and their *ex ante* TV channel preferences. Those who voted for the government party are colored in orange. National elections took place on 14 May 2023. Source: Authors' calculations based on KUHIES.

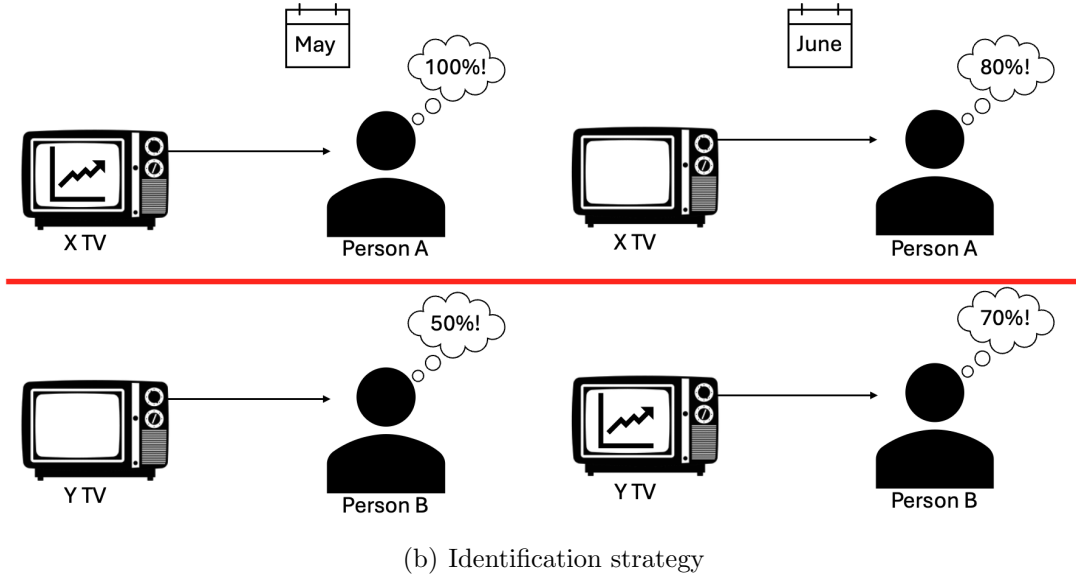
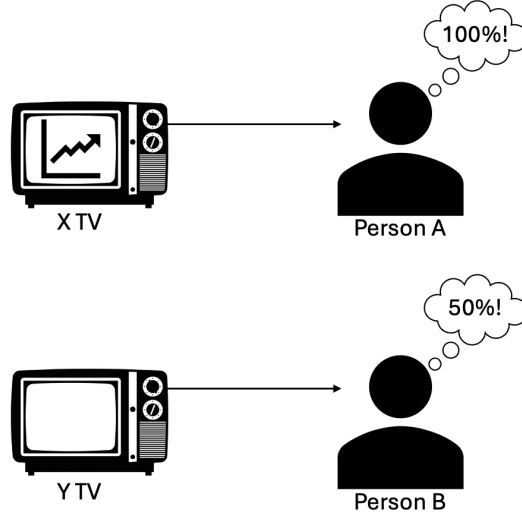
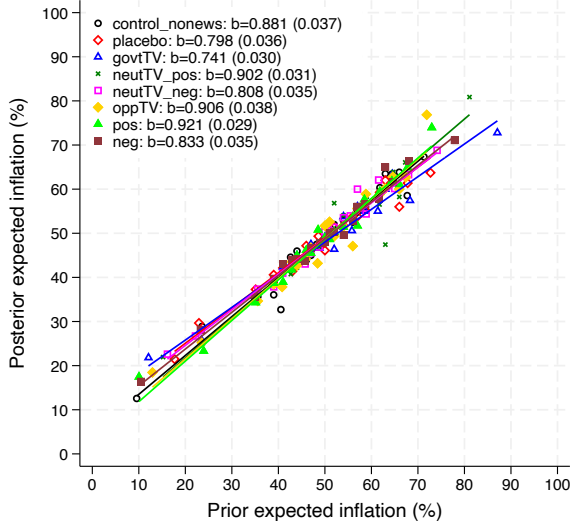
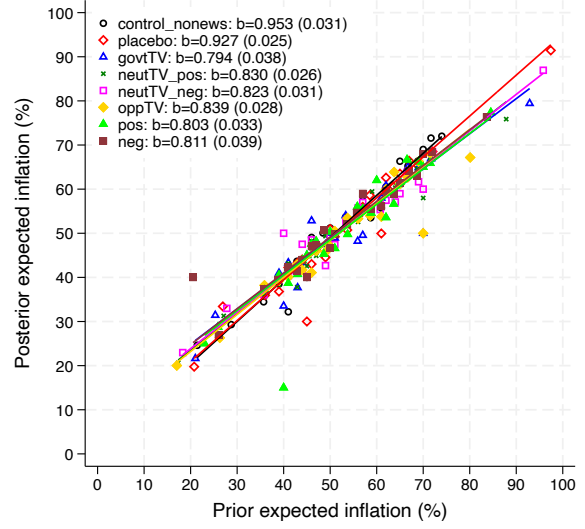


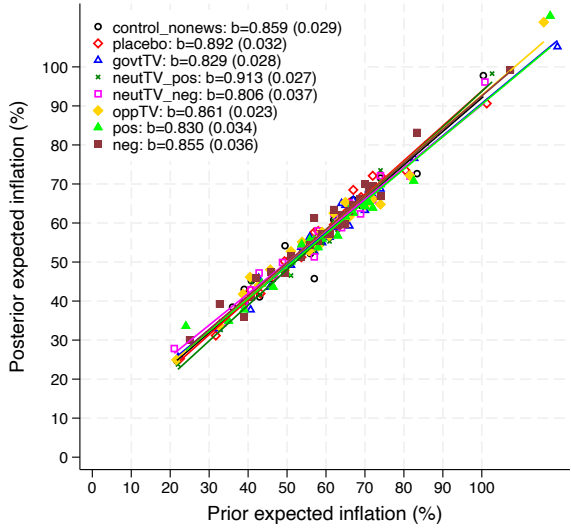
Fig. 6. Identification Problem vs. Strategy. This figure represents (a) the identification problem in a cross-sectional setting due to the possibility of individuals self-selecting themselves to TV channels aligned with their inflation outlook (b) the identification strategy in a panel setting in which the same individual-channel pair can be compared across different points in time.



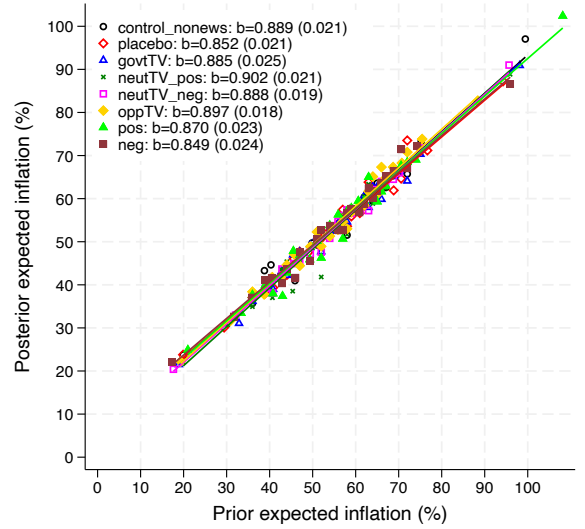
(a) Pro-gov't channel viewers



(b) Neutral channel viewers



(c) Pro-opp'n channel viewers



(d) Non-viewers

Fig. 7. Randomized Control Trial (RCT): Exposure to Media Slant and Inflation Expectations · [by *ex ante* TV channel preference]. This figure shows the bin-scatter plots and lines of best fit from separate Huber-robust regressions for each treatment and control group in which respondents' *Posterior* is regressed on their *Prior* inflation expectations. Different panels illustrate the same estimations separately for viewers of channels with different political alignments. Source: Authors' calculations based on RCT.

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N	Source
Inflation expectations	101.154	57.490	20	300	9253	KUHIES
Perceived past inflation	110.492	54.811	40	300	7227	KUHIES
Pro-government channel	0.356	0.479	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Neutral channel	0.170	0.376	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Pro-opposition channel	0.474	0.499	0	1	9253	KUHIES
AKPvote2023	0.371	0.483	0	1	8699	KUHIES
Non-AKPvote2023	0.629	0.483	0	1	8699	KUHIES
Inflation mentions on TV	4.527	3.388	0	19	9253	YouTube & Dailymotion
Inflation-related optimism on TV	-0.297	0.549	-1	1	9012	YouTube & Dailymotion
Election mentions on TV	6.876	5.321	0	36	9253	YouTube & Dailymotion
Distance to election (in months)	4.843	2.744	0	9	9253	Authors' calculations
CPI inflation rate	59.895	10.099	47	75	9253	TCMB
Posterior	52.162	13.864	2	160	8159	RCT
Prior	53.758	14.534	2	160	8159	RCT
Positive slant (Pro-gov't TV logo)	0.123	0.329	0	1	8159	RCT
Positive slant (Neutral TV logo)	0.124	0.330	0	1	8159	RCT
Negative slant (Neutral TV logo)	0.121	0.327	0	1	8159	RCT
Negative slant (Pro-opp'n TV logo)	0.124	0.329	0	1	8159	RCT
Positive slant (No TV logo)	0.128	0.334	0	1	8159	RCT
Negative slant (No TV logo)	0.127	0.333	0	1	8159	RCT
Placebo text (No TV logo)	0.123	0.328	0	1	8159	RCT
Pro-gov't channel	0.205	0.404	0	1	8159	RCT
Neutral channel	0.174	0.379	0	1	8159	RCT
Pro-opp'n channel	0.248	0.432	0	1	8159	RCT
Non-viewer	0.374	0.484	0	1	8159	RCT
Believes in heterodox policy	0.536	0.499	0	1	8159	RCT
Distrusts gov't policies	0.443	0.497	0	1	8159	RCT
Votes for AKP	0.262	0.440	0	1	8159	RCT
Donates more to AKP	0.096	0.295	0	1	8159	RCT

Table 1: **Summary Statistics for Main Variables.** The table lists all the variables used in the main analyses of the paper. See Table D1 for the control variables used in the panel analysis and Table D2 for the additional variables employed in robustness checks reported in the online appendix. See Table E2 for the control variables used in the RCT. For the specific definitions and construction of variables, see Section 3 as well as Online Appendix C. The final column displays the data sources.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome →	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party × Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province × Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
R-squared	0.030	0.106	0.552	0.558	0.565	0.610
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545

Table 2: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations.** The table summarizes the results of equation 1 estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\rightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV	1.730*** [0.369]	2.000*** [0.389]	1.550*** [0.468]	0.922* [0.541]	1.501** [0.597]	1.362** [0.599]
Inflation-related Optimism on TV	-0.092*** [0.021]	-0.058** [0.023]	0.058** [0.025]	-0.015 [0.028]	-0.022 [0.030]	-0.041 [0.030]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
R-squared	0.030	0.104	0.551	0.557	0.564	0.610
Observations	11,617	9,012	8,943	8,943	8,415	8,319

Table 3: Inflation Mentions & Optimism on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations. The table summarizes the results of equation 1 estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). *Inflation-related Optimism on TV* is a measure of optimistic tone around “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Inflation-related optimism is measured by a fine-tuned BERT model pre-trained on Turkish text (see [Online Appendix C](#) for details). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome →	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>			<i>Perceived Past Inflation (next month)</i>		
Inflation mentions on TV	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]	0.180 [0.516]	-0.217 [0.579]	0.006 [0.555]
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	Yes	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party × Time FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Province × Time FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
R-squared	0.558	0.565	0.610	0.575	0.581	0.622
Observations	9,188	8,644	8,545	8,698	8,199	8,118

Table 4: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Perceived Inflation in the Past Year.** The table summarizes the results of equation 1 estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. Dependent variable is either *Inflation Expectations* defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations or *Perceived Past Inflation* defined as a continuous variable measuring past-12-month inflation estimates of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome →	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV	1.084*** [0.210]	1.339*** [0.244]	0.645 [0.403]	0.850* [0.434]	1.421*** [0.500]	1.202** [0.480]
Perceived Past Inflation	0.698*** [0.017]	0.698*** [0.020]	0.534*** [0.025]	0.537*** [0.025]	0.536*** [0.025]	0.533*** [0.024]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party × Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province × Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
R-squared	0.448	0.497	0.718	0.719	0.724	0.755
Observations	9,547	7,227	7,132	7,132	6,713	6,636

Table 5: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations [controlling for perceived inflation in the past year]**. The table summarizes the results of equation 1 estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). *Perceived Past Inflation* is defined as a continuous variable measuring past-12-month inflation estimates of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome →	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	(2SLS)	(First stage)	(2SLS)	(First stage)	(2SLS)	(First stage)
	Inf.Expectations	Inf.Mentions	Inf.Expectations	Inf.Mentions	Inf.Expectations	Inf.Mentions
Inflation mentions on TV	4.529*** [0.524]	.	4.294*** [0.555]	.	5.713*** [0.938]	.
Distance to election (in months)		0.009*** [0.000]		0.009*** [0.000]		0.005*** [0.000]
CPI inflation rate	-0.001** [0.001]	0.002*** [0.000]	-0.002** [0.001]	0.002*** [0.000]	-0.002*** [0.001]	0.001*** [0.000]
Election mentions on TV	0.001 [0.001]	0.002*** [0.000]	-0.008*** [0.002]	0.004*** [0.000]	-0.002 [0.002]	0.001*** [0.000]
Individual controls	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	11,887	11,887	9,253	9,253	9,188	9,188
First-stage Kleibergen-Paap F-stat		3353.75		1136.83		606.67
First-stage Montiel-Pflueger F-stat		3353.75		1299.63		1008.36

Table 6: ***Instrumented Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations.*** The table summarizes the results of 2SLS estimations over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is instrumented with *Distance to election (in months)* which measures the number of months between a survey wave and the local elections that took place in March, 2024. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). *CPI inflation rate* is the monthly CPI inflation rate and *Election Mentions on TV* is the number of “election” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. First-stage Montiel-Pflueger F -stat tests for weak instruments in the first-stage estimation are implemented in a way that is robust to heteroskedasticity, autocorrelation, and clustering. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome →	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV x Pro-government channel	2.980 [1.914]	2.551 [1.924]	1.892 [2.063]	1.171 [1.295]	1.856 [1.342]	1.451 [1.476]
Inflation mentions on TV x Neutral channel	5.491*** [1.573]	4.566*** [1.578]	5.069*** [1.659]	3.989*** [1.082]	3.085*** [0.974]	3.490*** [1.039]
Inflation mentions on TV x Pro-opposition channel	0.887 [0.545]	0.719 [0.590]	1.247* [0.646]	0.101 [0.432]	0.310 [0.410]	0.369 [0.486]
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	Yes	No	No	Yes	No	No
Province × Time FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Party × Time FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Observations	9,188	9,091	8,545	9,687	9,596	9,023
Outcome format	Continuous	Continuous	Continuous	Binary	Binary	Binary

Table 7: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [by channel type]. The table summarizes the results of equation 1 estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024 with mutually exclusive (and exhaustive) interaction coefficients for channels of different political alignments. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome →	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV x Pro-gov't channel x AKPvote2023	4.215** [2.106]	3.192 [2.214]	1.706 [2.380]	0.912 [1.326]	1.431 [1.382]	-0.080 [1.537]
Inflation mentions on TV x Pro-gov't channel x Non-AKPvote2023	-0.612 [4.383]	1.031 [4.117]	3.005 [4.258]	2.100 [3.319]	3.744 [3.201]	4.993 [3.279]
Inflation mentions on TV x Neutral channel x AKPvote2023	8.545*** [2.513]	8.610*** [2.559]	7.809*** [2.568]	4.308*** [1.549]	4.345*** [1.458]	3.664** [1.424]
Inflation mentions on TV x Neutral channel x Non-AKPvote2023	4.230** [1.993]	2.945 [2.058]	3.652* [2.185]	4.206*** [1.469]	2.793** [1.308]	3.423** [1.435]
Inflation mentions on TV x Pro-opp'n channel x AKPvote2023	0.652 [1.123]	0.958 [1.151]	0.676 [1.160]	-0.090 [0.733]	0.334 [0.768]	0.204 [0.781]
Inflation mentions on TV x Pro-opp'n channel x Non-AKPvote2023	1.001 [0.629]	0.784 [0.702]	1.416* [0.763]	0.054 [0.494]	0.229 [0.482]	0.496 [0.591]
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	Yes	No	No	Yes	No	No
Province × Time FE	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Party × Time FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Observations	8,644	8,545	8,545	9,118	9,023	9,023
Outcome format	Cont.	Cont.	Cont.	Binary	Binary	Binary

Table 8: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [by channel and viewer type].

The table summarizes the results of equation 1 estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024 with mutually exclusive (and exhaustive) interaction coefficients for channels and viewers of different political alignments. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets.

*Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome $\rightarrow$	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
	<i>Posterior</i>				
Prior $\times$ Positive slant (Pro-gov't TV logo)	-0.057*** [0.019]	-0.140*** [0.048]	-0.158*** [0.049]	-0.031 [0.040]	-0.004 [0.032]
Prior $\times$ Positive slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.005 [0.018]	0.022 [0.048]	-0.123*** [0.041]	0.054 [0.040]	0.014 [0.029]
Prior $\times$ Negative slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.034* [0.018]	-0.073 [0.051]	-0.129*** [0.044]	-0.053 [0.047]	-0.000 [0.028]
Prior $\times$ Negative slant (Pro-opp'n TV logo)	-0.007 [0.018]	0.026 [0.053]	-0.113*** [0.042]	0.002 [0.037]	0.008 [0.027]
Prior $\times$ Positive slant (No TV logo)	-0.026 [0.019]	0.040 [0.047]	-0.150*** [0.046]	-0.029 [0.045]	-0.019 [0.031]
Prior $\times$ Negative slant (No TV logo)	-0.038* [0.020]	-0.048 [0.051]	-0.141*** [0.050]	-0.004 [0.047]	-0.039 [0.032]
Prior $\times$ Placebo text (No TV logo)	-0.021 [0.018]	-0.082 [0.052]	-0.026 [0.040]	0.032 [0.044]	-0.037 [0.029]
Prior	0.891*** [0.013]	0.881*** [0.037]	0.953*** [0.031]	0.859*** [0.029]	0.889*** [0.021]
Sample of channel viewers	All	Pro-gov't channel	Neutral channel	Pro-opp'n channel	Non-viewer
Baseline treatments controlled	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	8,156	1,666	1,401	2,065	3,028

Table 9: **Randomized Control Trial (RCT): Exposure to Media Slant and Inflation Expectations.** The table summarizes the results of equation 2 estimated over the full RCT sample as well as subsamples of viewers preferring TV channels of different political alignments. Dependent variable is *Posterior*, defined as a continuous variable measuring the post-treatment 12-month-ahead inflation expectations (mode) of respondents included in the RCT. *Prior* is a continuous variable measuring the pre-treatment 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in the RCT. See Section 4 for the construction of treatment indicators, Table 1 for summary statistics and Table E2 for the individual-level control variables. All regressions are estimated with Huber weights and robust standard errors are reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome →	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	<i>Believes in heterodox policy</i>		<i>Distrusts gov't policies</i>		<i>Votes for AKP</i>		<i>Donates more to AKP</i>	
Inflation Expectations (Posterior)	-0.019 [0.024]	-0.019 [0.024]	0.033 [0.024]	0.037 [0.024]	-0.050** [0.020]	-0.048** [0.020]	-0.031* [0.016]	-0.031* [0.016]
Weak-IV <i>p</i> -value	0.442	0.442	0.167	0.129	0.007	0.008	0.043	0.043
Weak-IV lower bound (95%)	-0.081	-0.081	-0.020	-0.014	-0.120	-0.119	-0.085	-0.087
Weak-IV upper bound (95%)	0.033	0.034	0.101	0.106	-0.014	-0.012	-0.001	-0.001
Individual controls	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
<i>F</i> -stat	8.245	7.899	8.245	7.899	8.245	7.899	8.245	7.899
Observations	1,243	1,243	1,243	1,243	1,243	1,243	1,243	1,243

Table 10: **Randomized Control Trial (RCT): *Instrumented* Inflation Expectations and Policy/Political Preferences.** The table summarizes the results of 2SLS estimations over the subsample of viewers preferring neutral TV channels. Placebo treatment group is dropped from these estimations. *Posterior* is instrumented with a general inflation-related treatment indicator as well as its interaction with *Prior*. Dependent variables are *Believes in heterodox policy*, which indicates if the respondent believes that “lower interest rates are needed to curb high inflation”; *Distrusts in gov’t policies*, which indicates whether the respondent has no trust at all in government’s economic policies; *Votes for AKP*, which indicates if the respondent would vote for the incumbent government party if an election was to take place on the day of the survey; and finally *Donates more to AKP*, which indicates if the respondent would split a hypothetical donation more in favor of an AKP voter than a non-AKP voter. *Posterior* is defined as a continuous variable measuring the post-treatment 12-month-ahead inflation expectations (mode) of respondents. *Prior* is a continuous variable measuring the pre-treatment 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents. See Section 4 for the construction of treatment indicators, Table 1 for summary statistics and Table E2 for the individual-level control variables. Weak-IV p-values and upper/lower bounds are reported for each estimate. All regressions are estimated with Huber weights and robust standard errors are reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%..

Online Appendix

POLARIZED MEDIA AND INFLATION EXPECTATIONS

Selva Demiralp

Orkun Saka

Michael Weber

July 2026

Appendix A - A Brief Overview of Inflationary Trends in Turkey

Following the severe financial crisis of 2001, Turkey implemented a comprehensive macroeconomic stabilization program that included major institutional reforms in monetary policy. During the period between 2001 and 2004, the Central Bank of the Republic of Turkey (CBRT) operated under a transitional framework of implicit inflation targeting. In 2005, the CBRT introduced pre-announced policy meeting dates, and in January 2006 it formally adopted an explicit inflation targeting (IT) regime. These reforms initially produced notable success in reducing inflation. As shown in Figure A2, the inflation rate declined rapidly in the early 2000s, reaching single-digit levels by the mid-2000s.

Despite this initial progress, the long-run performance of the inflation targeting regime has been considerably weaker. Although inflation remained in the high single digits for much of the period following the adoption of explicit inflation targeting, it generally exceeded the official target set by the CBRT. Over time, this persistent gap between realized inflation and the target weakened the credibility of the inflation targeting framework. The deterioration became particularly pronounced in the late 2010s. The exchange rate crisis of 2018 triggered a sharp acceleration in inflation, and the expansionary policies implemented in the period leading up to the 2023 general elections further intensified inflationary pressures. As a result, annual inflation reached a peak of approximately 65 percent in 2023 and 2024. While inflation began to decline following the return to more orthodox macroeconomic policies after the 2023 elections, the disinflation process has remained gradual.

The past performance of a central bank within an inflation targeting regime is one of the key determinants of its credibility. When credibility is weak and long-term inflation expectations are not well anchored, economic agents tend to update their expectations based on past inflation outcomes. In such environments, inflation expectations can become self-reinforcing, generating persistent inflation dynamics (Davis, 2014). The evidence presented in Figure 1 suggests that although the CBRT initially made progress in establishing credibility under the inflation targeting framework, this reputation has gradually eroded over time. During the roughly twenty-five years since the introduction of explicit inflation targeting, inflation has met the official target in only a small number of years and has exhibited an upward trend, particularly during the past decade. The deterioration in inflation performance may therefore have weakened the CBRT's anti-inflation credibility and increased the importance of alternative sources of information, such as media coverage, in shaping household inflation expectations.

Several factors may explain the disappointing performance of the inflation targeting

regime in Turkey. One important factor is the global macroeconomic environment. Shortly after the regime was introduced, the global economy experienced the 2007–2009 financial crisis. In response to the crisis, advanced economy central banks implemented large-scale liquidity injections and maintained extremely accommodative monetary policies. The resulting surge in global liquidity created significant challenges for emerging market economies. In particular, central banks faced difficult trade-offs between maintaining price stability and managing financial stability risks associated with large capital inflows. In such an environment, implementing sufficiently tight monetary policy to control inflation became more difficult (Alper et al., 2018). Global inflationary pressures intensified once again in the post-pandemic period. Nevertheless, global factors alone cannot fully explain Turkey’s inflation performance. Both in the period after GFC and after the pandemic, many emerging markets faced similar external conditions. However, Turkey’s average inflation rate remained significantly higher than that of most peers as shown in Figure A3. This comparison suggests that domestic factors played an important role in the persistent deviation of inflation from the CBRT’s target.

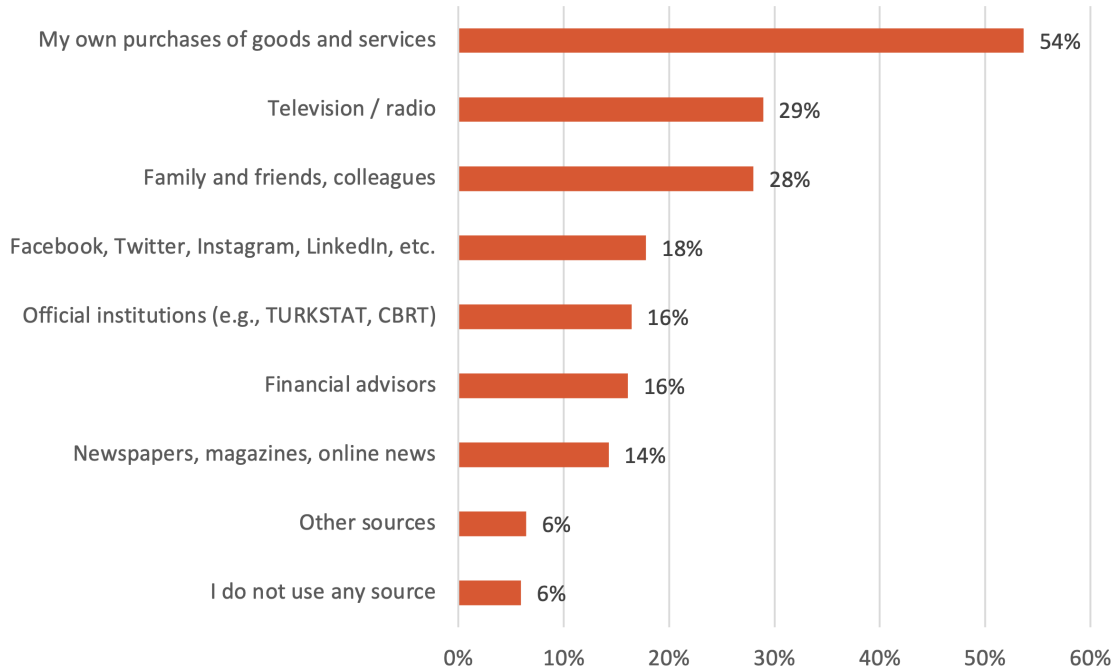


Fig. A1. **Sources of Inflation-related Information for Survey Participants (as of December, 2025).** The figure is based on data from the Koç University Household Inflation Expectations Survey (December 2025 wave). In December, survey participants were asked to indicate the sources they rely on to obtain information about inflation; the bars represent the share of respondents selecting each option. The survey is designed to measure and track inflation perceptions among a nationally representative sample of Turkey’s adult population aged 18 and above. Data collection was conducted between December 12 and 22, 2025, with a total of 4,740 respondents. Further information about the survey is available at: <https://case.ku.edu.tr/en/turkiye-household-inflation-expectations-survey/>.

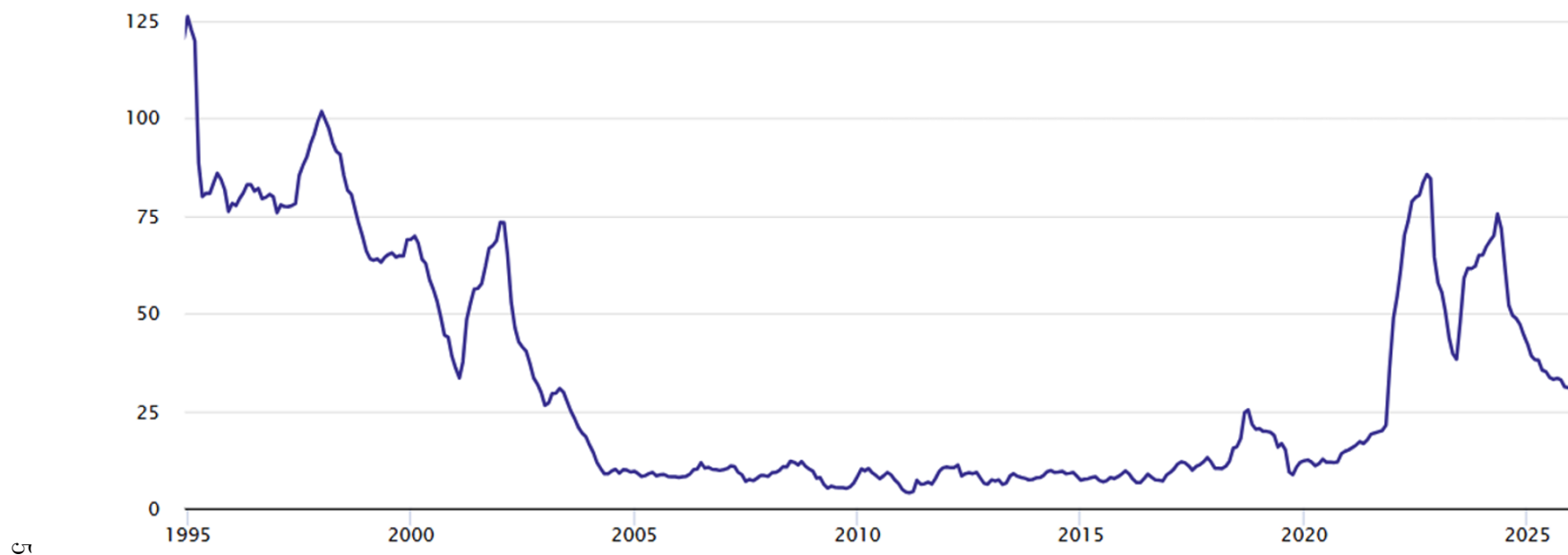
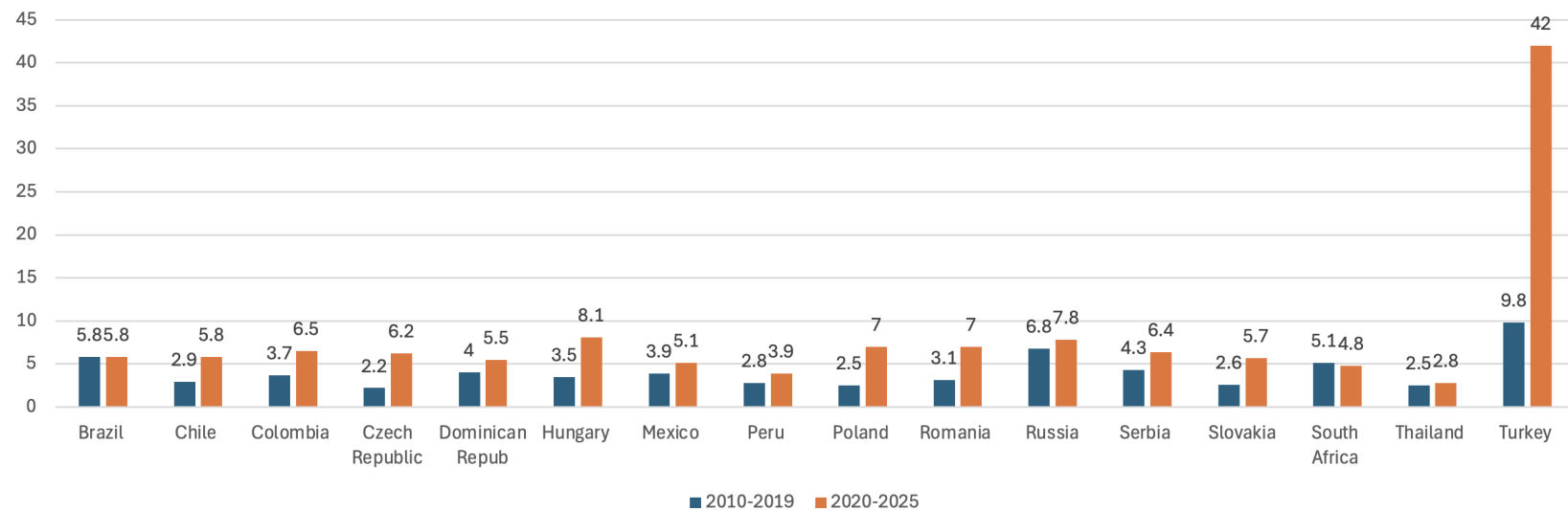


Fig. A2. **Official inflation rate in Turkey.** The figure displays Turkey's official headline inflation rate (year-on-year CPI) from 1995 to the present, sourced from the Turkish Statistical Institute (TÜİK/TURKSTAT). Data are available at: <https://www.tuik.gov.tr/>.



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Fig. A3. Average Inflation Rate in Selected Emerging Market Economies. The figure reports average annual CPI inflation rates for two sub-periods, 2010–2019 and 2020–2025, across a sample of emerging market economies. Data are sourced from the World Bank World Development Indicators (WDI). Averages are computed over the respective sub-periods using annual inflation figures. Data are available at: <https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>.

Appendix B - The Relationship between Media and Government in Turkey

Understanding Turkey’s recent media system

The literature has long considered Turkey’s media system in line with Hallin and Mancini’s Mediterranean or Polarized Pluralist model. This model has been characterized by Southern European media systems, including those of Italy, Spain, and Greece, and defined by four interrelated dimensions: the structure of media markets, the degree of political parallelism, the professionalization of journalism, and the role of the state (Hallin & Mancini, 2004).

Akser and Baybars (2024) further argue that Turkey has recently moved beyond the Mediterranean model’s parameters. Starting from early 2010s, Turkey has undergone a fundamental systemic transition, one from the Polarized Pluralist model toward a fully captured media model in which the control over the majority of media is consolidated under the ruling party and institutional space for dissenting voices is systematically contracted. This transition is characterized by three mutually reinforcing dynamics: direct and indirect state intervention in media content, the concentration of ownership in pro-government business entities, and the erosion of journalistic professionalism as a normative constraint on editorial conduct (Akser & Baybars-Hawks, 2024).

A brief history of the media market and capture

Turkey’s media transformation under AKP rule did not happen overnight, nor did it require a single dramatic rupture. It unfolded gradually, through a sequence of ownership transfers, financial pressures, and regulatory maneuvers that might each appear unremarkable. Taken together, they produced something persisting over the years. By 2014, the cumulative effect of these dynamics was visible in international indicators: Turkey’s press freedom classification dropped from “partly free” to “not free” on the Freedom House index for the first time in fifteen years (Yanardağoglu, 2021). In those years after 2014, Turkey’s media freedom went down year by year (İnceoglu et al., 2020, 2021; İnceoglu et al., 2022, 2023; Erbaysal Filibeli et al., 2024).

The economic liberalization of the 1980s opened Turkish media to private capital, producing new outlets, new voices, and a genuine –if imperfect– pluralism (Akser, 2018; Yanardağoglu, 2021). Yet as Kurban and Sözeri (2012) were among the first to observe, this economic opening was never matched by a corresponding democratization of the political sphere. Instead, a landscape appeared of nominally diverse owners who were, in practice, bound to the state through their wider business interests. These conglomerates who oper-

ated simultaneously in construction, energy, banking, and media could not afford to treat journalism as a purely independent enterprise. Their media holdings were one asset among many, and those assets depended on state’s favoritism across the entire portfolio.

The turning point came after 2007, once the brief reformist window of 2002–2007 had closed in the AKP era. During this process, the first targets were the most visibly oppositional. Cem Uzan’s media group whose outlets had been openly critical of Prime Minister Erdoğan was subjected to regulatory intervention by the banking regulator, and its assets, including Star TV, were seized and eventually passed to the Doğan Media Group 2004 (Yıldırım et al., 2021). The Ciner Group’s flagship outlets Sabah and ATV were similarly captured and transferred to the Çalık Group, whose proximity to Erdoğan’s son-in-law made the political logic of the arrangement transparent (Akser & Baybars-Hawks, 2012; Akser & Baybars-Hawks, 2024). By 2008, the Doğan Group had emerged as Turkey’s undisputed media hegemon; having integrated assets seized from bankrupt competitors like the Bilgin and Uzan groups, it effectively controlled more than 50% of the nation’s news and entertainment platforms across all media sectors (Greenslade, 2009).

In 2009, Turkish tax authorities levied penalties totaling approximately 4.5 billion dollars on Doğan Media for alleged tax irregularities. This intervention was widely understood as political rather than fiscal (Akser, 2018; Yanardağoglu, 2021). The penalties forced the sale of Milliyet and Vatan newspapers to pro-government buyers and left the group financially weakened and editorially chastened. By 2018, what remained of Doğan’s empire (Hürriyet, Kanal D, CNN Türk) had been sold to the Demirören Group, financed through a 675 million dollar loan from the state-owned Ziraat Bank, extended on terms no commercial lender would have offered (RSF, 2018; Akser & Baybars-Hawks, 2024). With that sale, the last major media group capable of maintaining institutional distance from the government ceased to exist.

The conglomerates that now dominate Turkish broadcasting are Kalyon/Turkuvaz (ATV, A Haber), Demirören (Kanal D), Doğuş (Star TV), Ciner (Show TV, Haber Türk) and all depend to some extent on public procurement for their non-media revenues (Yanardağoglu, 2021; Kırdemir, 2020).³⁸ According to the Media Ownership Monitor, more than 80 percent of Turkey’s media outlets are now owned by entities with economic or political ties to the ruling party (RSF, 2021, as cited in Erbaysal Filibeli et al., 2024). The channels that resulted from this ownership consolidation have been described by Yanardağoglu (2021) and Akser (2018) as “pool media” (havuz medyası) defined as assets circulated through informal networks to figures close to the ruling circle, functioning less as media businesses than as

³⁸Despite its closeness to the government circles, we categorize Demirören TV media (i.e., Kanal D) as neutral due to its historically more critical stance in the hands of its previous owner.

instruments of partisan communication. Yıldırım et al. (2021) confirm that these ownership transfers were followed not by commercial recovery but by audience attrition of roughly 13 percent within a year of sale, which implies media capture follows political rather than economic goals.

The editorial consequences of this structure are well-documented. Captured outlets deploy a consistent repertoire: positive framing of government policy, suppression of news that might reflect poorly on the administration, and active negative framing of opposition figures through recurring accusations of terrorism sympathy, separatism, and lack of national belonging (Akser & Baybars-Hawks, 2024).¹

Yıldırım et al. (2021) theorize the broader electoral implication of this configuration as an “incumbency bonus” intensified by competitive authoritarianism. Through content analysis of four consecutive national election campaigns, they show that pro-government outlets gave the AKP increasing visibility and decreasing critical coverage over time, while the main opposition received the inverse. By the 2015 campaign, the AKP was receiving approximately 4.5 times more coverage than its main rival.² Unlike the incumbency bonuses documented in consolidated democracies where commercial logic may simply favor coverage of whoever holds power, the Turkish case reflects fear of ownership reprisal: editors make decisions based on anticipation of government response, not assessments of news value. The mechanism behind this behavior is captured in Över’s (2021) phrase: “Mr. Erdoğan would be angry” journalism — a culture in which the primary editorial filter is not newsworthiness or accuracy but the anticipated reaction of the presidency.

Regulation of TV media as a punishment tool

Within the television sector specifically, the regulatory framework has been turned into an instrument of asymmetric enforcement during the AKP era. The main regulator, RTÜK (Radio and Television Supreme Council), is composed of nine members elected by parliament in proportion to party representation, with no independent voice from media organizations, trade unions, or academia. In 2021, all 71 monetary penalties issued by the council went to opposition or critical channels; not a single fine was levied against a pro-government outlet (İnceoğlu et al., 2022). In the first half of 2023, the campaign period for presidential and parliamentary elections, fines against opposition-aligned channels totaled nearly 2.25 million

¹Akkus (2023) tracks one particularly striking manifestation of this coordination. The copycat headline phenomenon, in which multiple newspapers hit newsstands on the same morning with identical front pages. On June 7, 2013, seven papers ran the same headline; by February 2018, the number had risen to sixteen.

²The 2023 elections showed the same dynamics in broadcasting, with OSCE/ODIHR observers documenting systematic bias in airtime and framing in favor of President Erdoğan across pro-government channels (Erbaysal Filibeli et al., 2024).

dollars across 59 cases, while the sole pro-government channel penalized during the same period paid under 11,000 dollars (Erbaysal Filibeli et al., 2024).

Transparency International’s analysis of 2020 RTÜK decisions found that 73 percent of broadcast suspensions and 69 percent of monetary fines in the news category were directed at just four channels: Halk TV, Tele 1, Fox TV, and KRT (İnceoglu et al., 2021). The financial asymmetry alone would be significant enough. But under Law No. 6112, three sanctions under the same provision within a single year triggers automatic license revocation which means RTÜK’s penalties function not merely as fines but as existential threats for oppositional channels, capable of shaping editorial behavior without ever being executed (İnceoglu et al., 2021).

In this environment, the channels that maintain critical or oppositional editorial lines such as Fox TV/Now TV, Halk TV, KRT, SZC TV do so under conditions of compounding institutional pressure that make their continued existence analytically interesting.³ For example, Fox TV –ranked as the most widely consumed television news source in Turkey in the 2019 Reuters Institute Digital News Report– still saw one of its anchors forced out following direct government pressure (Kirdemir, 2020; Human Rights Watch, 2020). Similarly, Halk TV has been sanctioned twice in a single year under Law No. 6112, bringing it within one infraction of license revocation (İnceoglu et al., 2021). SZC TV’s parent newspaper Sözcü was subjected to four days of BİK advertising bans in a single year, while pro-government outlets faced no equivalent action (İnceoglu et al., 2023).

³Yıldırım et al. (2021), drawing on Levitsky and Way’s (2002) theory of competitive authoritarianism, note that opposition media can persist in such systems precisely because their complete elimination would attract international attention. Their persistence is not evidence of functioning pluralism; it is evidence that the system has calibrated suppression carefully enough to maintain the appearance of competition.

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Appendix C - Details of the Language Models for Inflation-related Optimism/Pessimism Measurement

We score inflation-related sentiment in Turkish television transcripts using four models: a fine-tuned Turkish BERT classifier (preferred model), a base version of the same classifier, and two prompting-based configurations of a large language model (zero-shot and ten-shot). The fine-tuned BERT is our preferred specification; the remaining three serve as robustness checks. All models operate on the same 30-word windows described below, and their outputs are validated against a common held-out test set of human-annotated windows.

Window construction

For each transcript we identify every occurrence of the root token *enflasyon* (inflation). Around each occurrence we extract a symmetric 30-word window: the 15 tokens immediately preceding the keyword and the 15 tokens immediately following it, after stripping speaker labels and punctuation artifacts introduced by the automatic speech recognition pipeline.⁴ A transcript containing k inflation mentions therefore contributes k windows. Across the 3,141 transcripts in our corpus, this procedure yields 13,526 scored windows.

Human annotation

A stratified random sample of 1941 windows was hand-labeled by three research assistants in a way that each window would be handled by two RAs. Each RA assigned a ternary score: +1 (optimistic), -1 (pessimistic), or 0 (neutral). We resolve disagreements as follows. We average the available scores across two RAs and round to the nearest integer. Windows where the two available scores are maximally divergent (+1 and -1, implying an average of exactly 0) are dropped as unresolvable. We also drop windows resolved to neutral (0), retaining only binary optimistic/pessimistic labels. After these exclusions the labeled sample comprises 796 windows.⁵ We split this sample into training (70%), validation (10%), and test (20%) sets using stratified random sampling, yielding 556 training, 80 validation, and 160 test windows.

⁴Where a window would extend beyond the start or end of the transcript, it is padded to the available text.

⁵Specifically, 266 optimistic and 530 pessimistic windows were retained for training the BERT model and for the few-shot prompt used for the LLM.

Models, fine-tuning and prompts

Base BERT: Our first classifier is a BERT-base model pre-trained on Turkish text and fine-tuned on a general Turkish sentiment corpus based on product and movie reviews (Yildirim, 2024). We apply it off-the-shelf, without any further fine-tuning on our domain. Outputs are two-class probabilities (positive and negative) that sum up to 1.0.

Fine-Tuned BERT (Preferred): We fine-tune the base BERT model on our RA-labeled training set (556 windows). All layers are updated using the AdamW optimiser with a learning rate of 2×10^{-5} and weight decay of 0.01. We train for up to five epochs with a batch size of 16, applying early stopping when validation accuracy fails to improve for two consecutive epochs (`patience=2`). Maximum sequence length is set to 128 tokens. Training is performed on Apple M1 GPU (MPS backend). The fine-tuned model weights are locally stored and are available upon request. Outputs are two-class probabilities (optimistic and pessimistic) that sum up to 1.0.

Zero-Shot Qwen2.5-14B: We query `qwen2.5:14b` (Ollama distribution, 14 billion parameter instruction-tuned model) with no labeled examples. The model receives a system prompt that defines the task—assessing whether a Turkish inflation excerpt conveys an optimistic or pessimistic narrative—and instructs it to respond with a JSON object containing two probabilities that sum to exactly 1.0.

Since an LLM with 14 billion parameters was too large to run on our local servers, we used Google Colab servers to run the model on the full dataset with A100 GPU and High-RAM options and by using two parallel worker threads. Model temperature was set to zero in order to maximize replicability.

The system prompt specifies that an optimistic narrative is one suggesting inflation is declining, under control, or that the economic outlook is improving; a pessimistic narrative suggests inflation is rising, problematic, or that the economic situation is worsening. Temperature is set to 0 for deterministic output. The following exact prompt template was used for each iterative call:

Zero-shot prompt:

You are an expert analyst of media narratives about inflation. You will be given a short excerpt from a Turkish TV news transcript containing a mention of inflation ("enflasyon").

Assess whether the excerpt conveys an optimistic or pessimistic narrative about inflation. Optimistic narratives suggest inflation is declining, under control, or that the economic outlook is improving. Pessimistic narratives suggest inflation is rising, problematic, or that the economic situation is worsening.

Provide two probabilities that sum to exactly 1.0: - optimistic: probability that the excerpt conveys an optimistic inflation narrative - pessimistic: probability that the excerpt conveys a pessimistic inflation narrative

Respond with JSON only - no explanation, no extra text. Example format: ({"optimistic": 0.30, "pessimistic": 0.70}).

Few-Shot Qwen2.5-14B: The few-shot configuration uses the same model and system prompt as above, augmented with ten labeled examples drawn from the training set. We sample five optimistic and five pessimistic examples and shuffle them into a random order, constructing alternating user/assistant turns in the conversation history before the target window. Each assistant turn contains the ground-truth JSON label ({"optimistic": 1.0, "pessimistic": 0.0} or vice versa).

All other hyperparameters are identical to the zero-shot configuration. Full-dataset scoring is similarly run on Google Colab Pro (NVIDIA A100 GPU, High-RAM runtime) using two parallel worker threads. The following exact prompt template was used for each iterative call:

Few-shot prompt:

You are an expert analyst of media narratives about inflation. You will be given a short excerpt from a Turkish TV news transcript containing a mention of inflation ("enflasyon").

Assess whether the excerpt conveys an optimistic or pessimistic narrative about inflation. Optimistic narratives suggest inflation is declining, under control, or that the economic outlook is improving. Pessimistic narratives suggest inflation is rising, problematic, or that the economic situation is worsening.

Provide two probabilities that sum to exactly 1.0: - optimistic: probability that the excerpt conveys an optimistic inflation narrative - pessimistic: probability that the excerpt conveys a pessimistic inflation narrative

Respond with JSON only - no explanation, no extra text. Example format: ({"optimistic": 0.30, "pessimistic": 0.70}).

Shot 1 [PESSIMISTIC]

USER: uyarısını ortaya koyuyor bu birincisi stagflasyon halimiz ikincisi türkîş sahay y iniyor efendim gördüğünüz gibi enflasyon ve işsizlik karşısında sokağa çıkma kararı türkîş kimdir asgari ücret tespit komisyonu masasında ne kadar

ASSISTANT: ({"optimistic": 0.0, "pessimistic": 1.0})

Shot 2 [OPTIMISTIC]

USER: kalacak ekonomide yaşanan gelişmeler de gündemindeydi enflasyondaki düşüşün en yakın zamanda hissedilecek söyledi önümüzdeki aylarda enflasyondaki düşüş devam edecek ve milletimiz bu düşüşü çarşıda pazarda alışveriş sepetinde mutfağında daha fazla hissedecektir

ASSISTANT: ({"optimistic": 1.0, "pessimistic": 0.0})

...

Shot 10 [PESSIMISTIC]

USER: yılın son enflasyon raporunu açıkladı bugün milyonların merakla beklediği asgari ücreti yapılacak zamdaydı gözler yüksek enflasyon ortamında ücretler real olarak erir bizim yapmamız gereken enflasyonu kalıcı bir şekilde düşürmek fiyat istikrarını

ASSISTANT: ({"optimistic": 0.0, "pessimistic": 1.0})

Final user turn at inference:

USER: [window text]

ASSISTANT: (model generates JSON) 17

Scoring and aggregation

Each model produces, for every window w in transcript i , a pair of probabilities $(p_{iw}^{\text{opt}}, p_{iw}^{\text{pess}})$ summing to 1. We define the *window-level net score* as

$$s_{iw} = p_{iw}^{\text{opt}} - p_{iw}^{\text{pess}} \in [-1, 1].$$

The *transcript-level net score* is the simple average across all windows in that transcript:

$$\bar{s}_i = \frac{1}{K_i} \sum_{w=1}^{K_i} s_{iw},$$

where K_i is the number of inflation-mention windows in transcript i . Transcripts with zero inflation mentions receive a missing net score and are excluded from channel-month aggregation.

Channel $\times$ month cell averages are computed by averaging $\bar{s}_i$ across all transcripts i belonging to channel c in month t . Cells with fewer than five qualifying transcripts are set to missing to avoid noisy estimates from very thin coverage.

Model performance

We evaluate all four models on the same 160-window held-out test set using three complementary metrics:

- **Accuracy** is the share of windows classified correctly. It is intuitive but can be misleading when classes are imbalanced: a model that always predicts the majority class would still achieve non-trivial accuracy.
- **Cohen’s κ** adjusts accuracy for the agreement that would arise by chance given the marginal class frequencies. Formally,

$$\kappa = \frac{p_o - p_e}{1 - p_e},$$

where p_o is observed accuracy and p_e is the probability of chance agreement. A value of $\kappa = 1$ indicates perfect classification; $\kappa = 0$ indicates performance no better than random; negative values indicate systematic misclassification. Because our test set contains approximately twice as many pessimistic windows as optimistic ones, κ is a more reliable summary of model quality than raw accuracy.

- **Macro-averaged F1** is the unweighted average of the per-class F1 scores, where the

F1 score for each class is the harmonic mean of precision and recall:

$$F_1^{(c)} = \frac{2 \cdot \text{precision}^{(c)} \cdot \text{recall}^{(c)}}{\text{precision}^{(c)} + \text{recall}^{(c)}}, \quad F_1^{\text{macro}} = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{c \in \{\text{opt}, \text{pess}\}} F_1^{(c)}.$$

Macro-averaging weights both classes equally regardless of their frequency, so a model that performs well on the dominant (pessimistic) class but poorly on the minority (optimistic) class is penalized accordingly.

Table C2 reports all three metrics for each model. The fine-tuned BERT achieves the highest κ and macro-F1, confirming it as the preferred specification even though it ties with ten-shot Qwen2.5-14B on raw accuracy. The baseline BERT’s low κ (0.431) reveals that its accuracy is partly explained by the class imbalance in the test set, rather than genuine discriminative power.

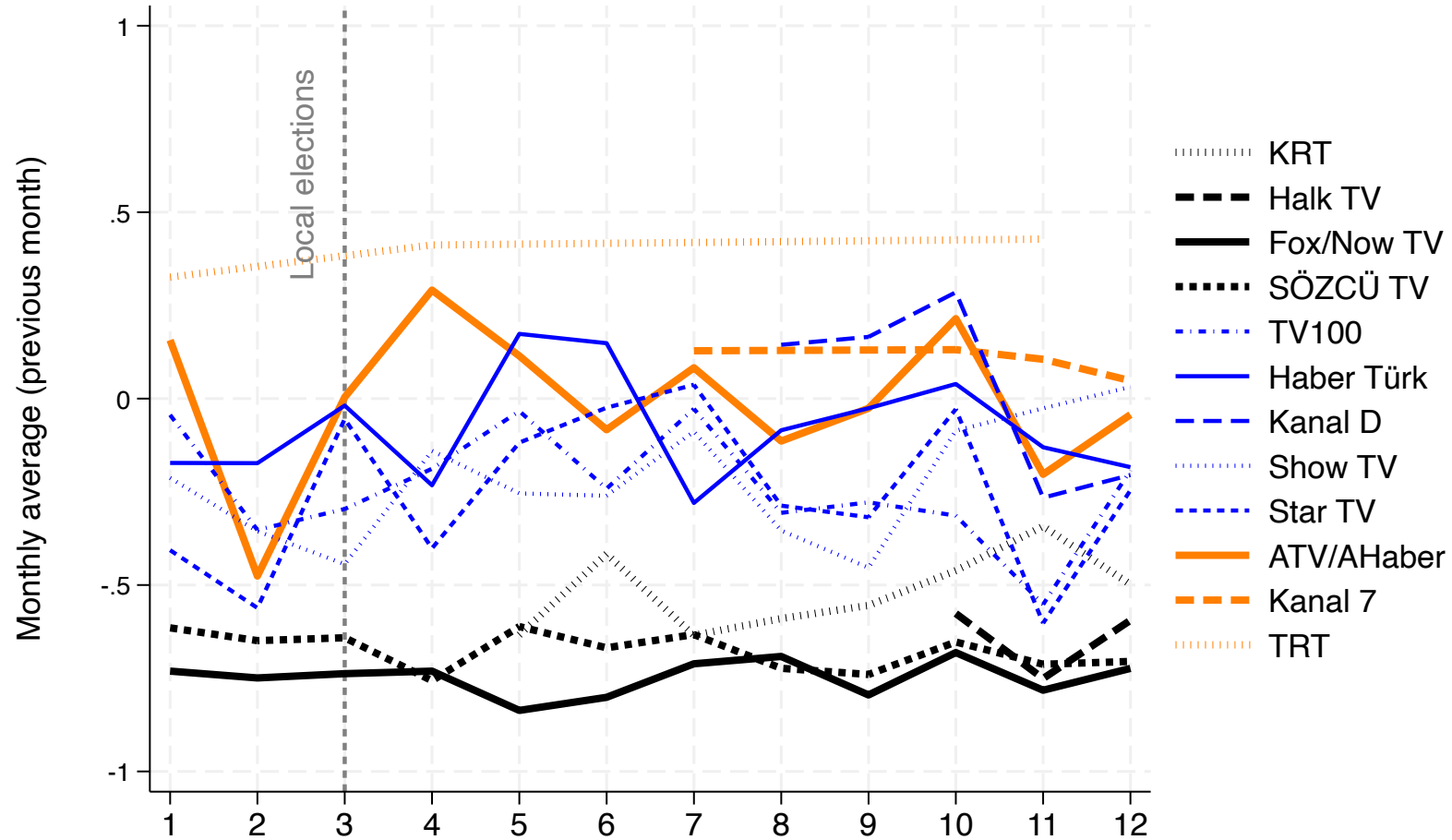
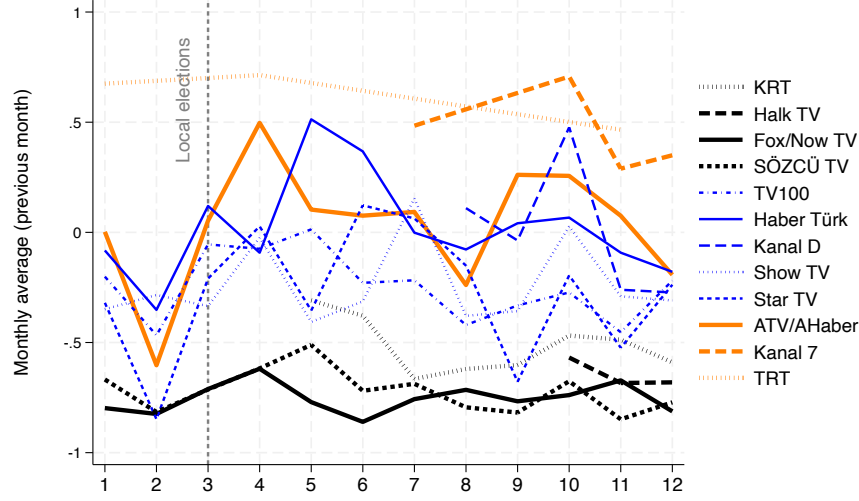
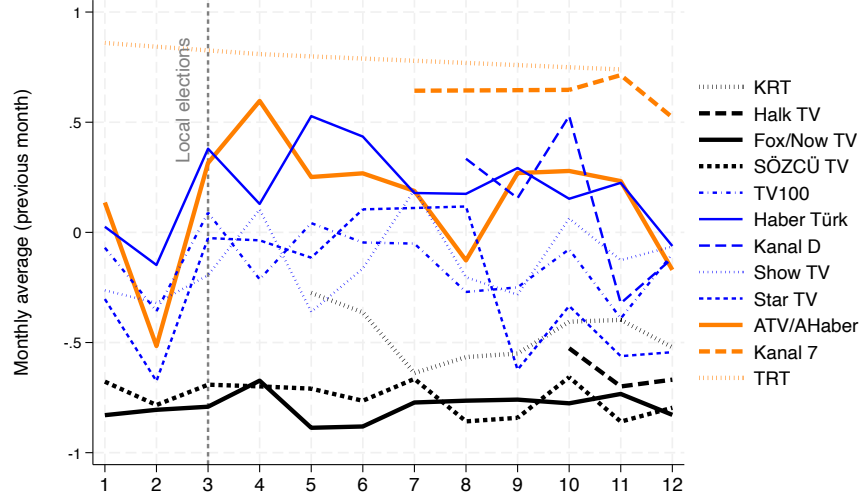


Fig. C1. **Inflation-related Sentiment Scores in Prime-time TV News (2024m1 - 2024m12).** This figure shows a measure of positive/negative tone around “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Context window around the “inflation” keyword is extracted as ± 30 words. Inflation-related optimism is measured by a BERT model pre-trained on Turkish text (see [Online Appendix C](#) for details). Pro-government channels are colored in orange, neutral channels are colored in blue and pro-opposition channels are colored in black. Local elections took place on 31 March 2024. Source: Authors’ calculations based on publicly available data on YouTube & Dailymotion.

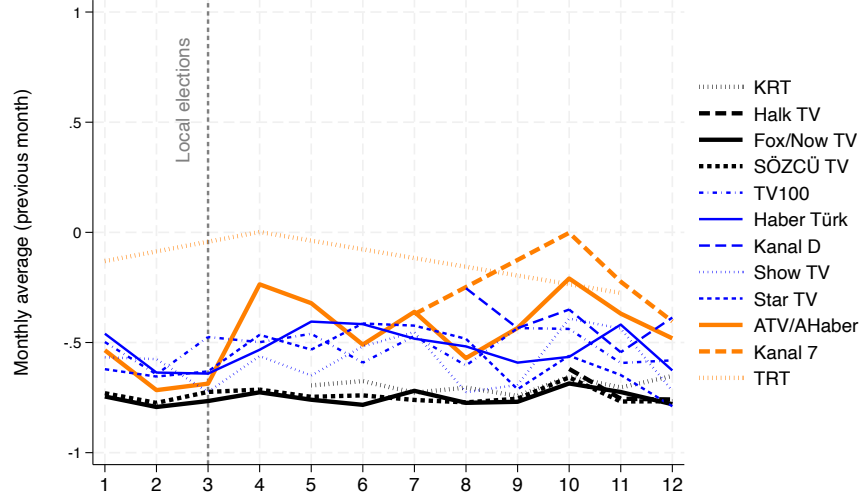


(a) Window: ± 15 Words

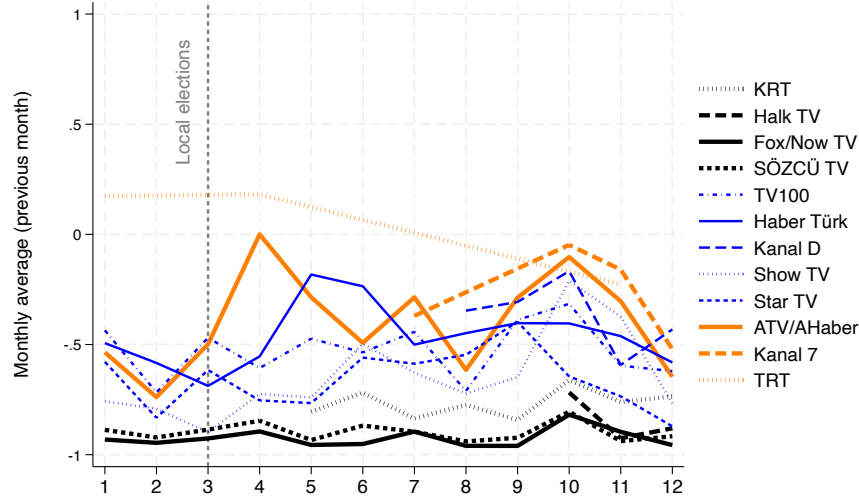


(b) Window: ± 50 Words

Fig. C2. Inflation-related Optimism/Pessimism in Prime-time TV News with Alternative Window Sizes around Keyword (2024m1 - 2024m12). This figure shows a measure of optimistic tone around “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Context window around the “inflation” keyword is extracted either as ± 15 words (panel A) or as ± 50 words (panel B). Inflation-related optimism is measured by a fine-tuned BERT model pre-trained on Turkish text (see [Online Appendix C](#) for details). Pro-government channels are colored in orange, neutral channels are colored in blue and pro-opposition channels are colored in black. Local elections took place on 31 March 2024. Source: Authors’ calculations based on publicly available data on YouTube & Dailymotion.



(a) Zero-shot version (Qwen2.5:14b)



(b) Few-shot version (Qwen2.5:14b)

Fig. C3. Inflation-related Sentiment Scores in Prime-time TV News Measured via a Large Language Model (2024m1 - 2024m12). This figure shows a measure of optimistic tone around “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Context window around the “inflation” keyword is extracted as ± 30 words. Inflation-related optimism is measured either by a zero-shot (panel A) or by a few-shot (panel A) large language model (LLM) with Turkish language capabilities (see [Online Appendix C](#) for details). Pro-government channels are colored in orange, neutral channels are colored in blue and pro-opposition channels are colored in black. Local elections took place on 31 March 2024. Source: Authors’ calculations based on publicly available data on YouTube & Dailymotion.

TV channel	Number of daily prime-time news videos/transcripts
ATV / A Haber	418
Fox TV - Now TV	365
Haber Türk	353
Halk TV	63
Kanal 7	103
Kanal D	159
KRT	226
Show TV	358
Star TV	363
TRT	104
SZC TV	361
TV100	268
TOTAL	3141

Table C1: **Number of Daily Prime-time News Videos/Transcripts by TV Channel.** This table reports the total number of daily prime-time news videos/transcripts available for each channel during our sample period. Pro-government channels are colored in orange, neutral channels are colored in blue and pro-opposition channels are colored in black. Source: Authors' calculations based on publicly available data on YouTube & Dailymotion.

Model	Accuracy	Cohen’s κ	F1 (macro)
Base BERT	0.756	0.431	0.715
Zero-shot Qwen2.5-14B	0.856	0.640	0.816
Few-shot Qwen2.5-14B	0.919	0.805	0.902
Fine-tuned BERT	0.919	0.826	0.912

Table C2: **Performance Metrics for Different Language Models.** This table reports the out-of-sample validation performance of different language models tested over the same sample of human-annotated labels (see [Online Appendix C](#) for details). Source: Authors’ calculations based on publicly available data on YouTube & Dailymotion and labels generated by three research assistants.

Appendix D - Robustness Checks (Panel Data)

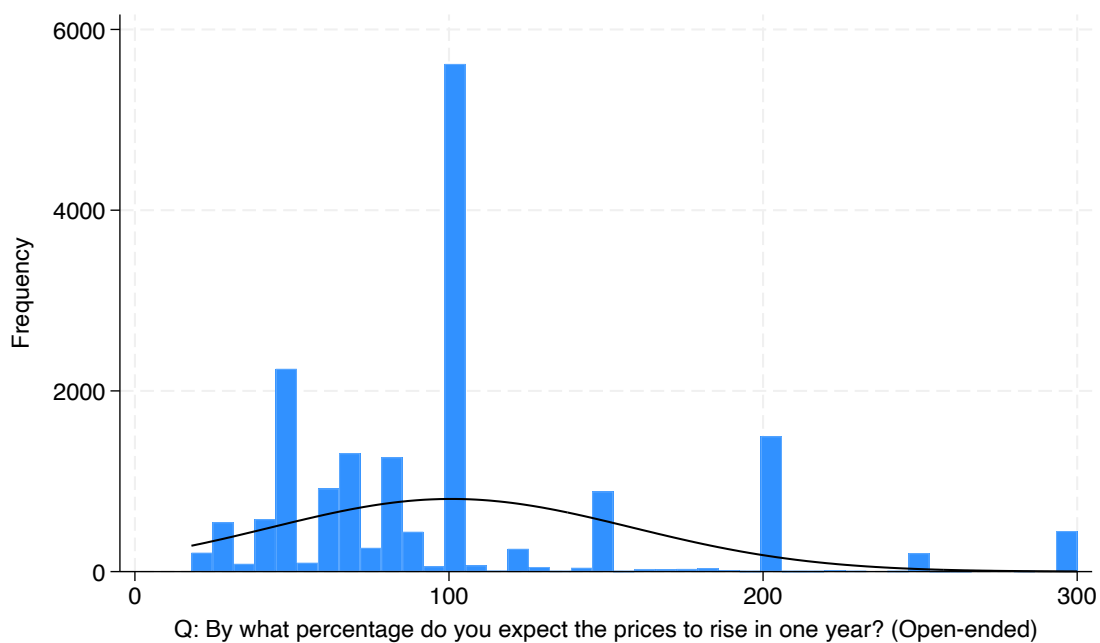


Fig. D1. **Within-sample histogram for inflation expectations.** This figure shows the general distribution of *Inflation Expectations* used as the outcome variable in our baseline setting. Source: Authors' calculations based on KUHIES.

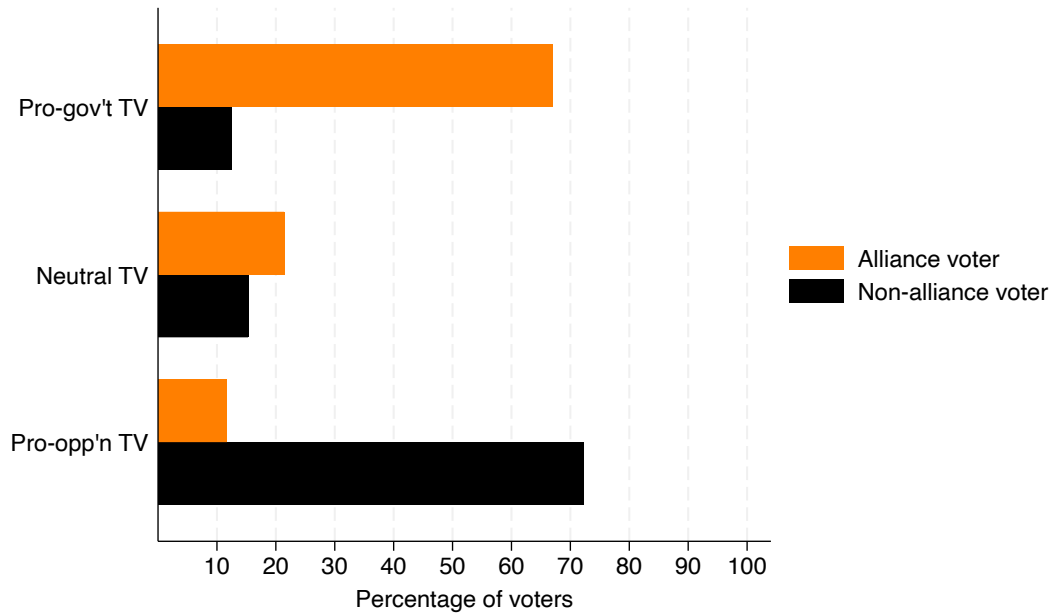


Fig. D2. **TV Viewership by 2023 Vote.** This figure shows the percentage of individuals in KUHIES who voted (or not) for the presidential alliance parties (AKP+MHP) during national elections in 2023 broken down by the same individuals' *ex ante* preferred TV channel for watching prime-time news. Presidential alliance voters are colored in orange and others are colored in black. National and presidential elections took place on 14 May 2023. Source: Authors' calculations based on KUHIES.

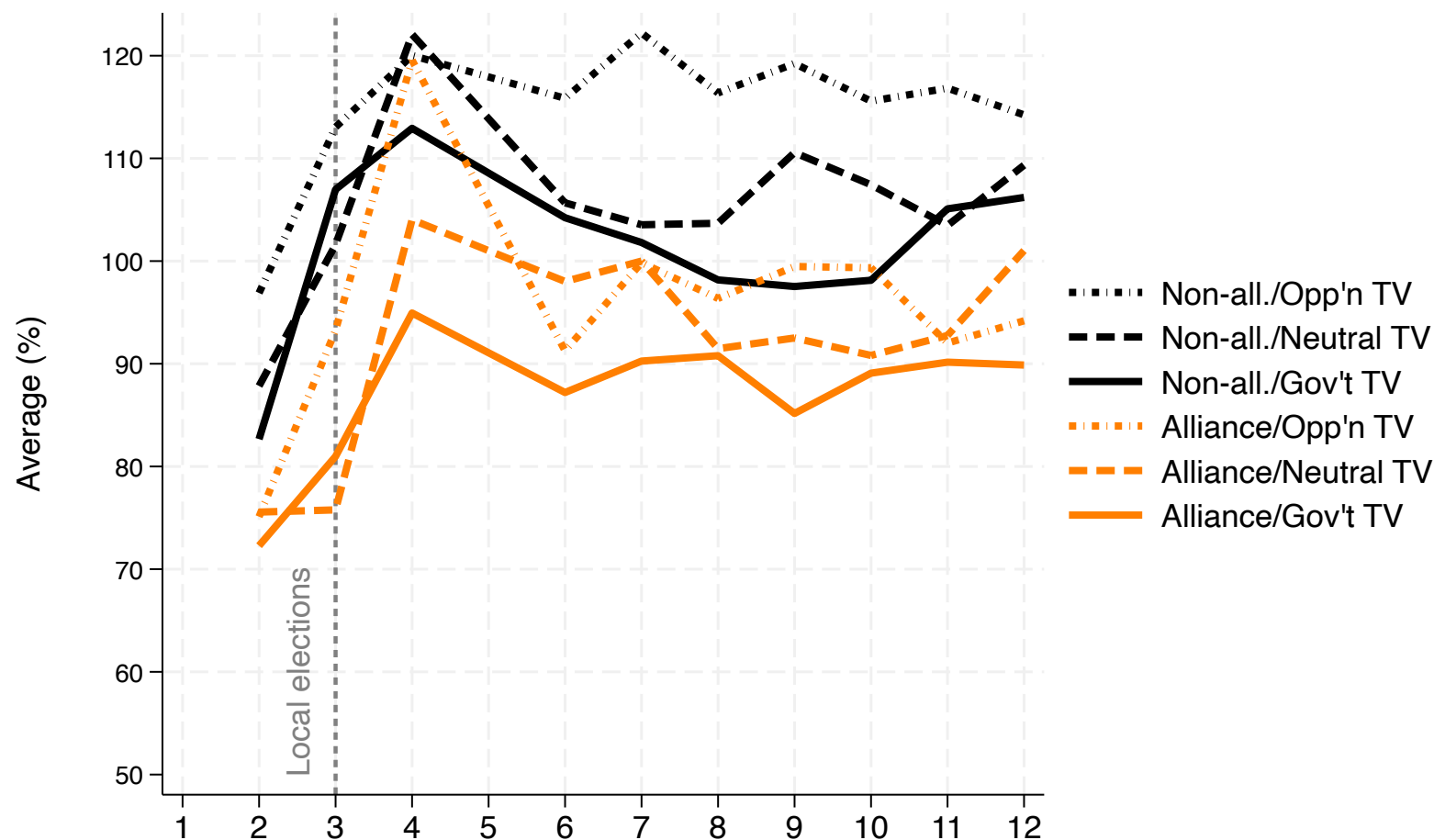


Fig. D3. **Household Inflation Expectations by 2023 Vote and *ex ante* TV Channel Preference (2024m1 - 2024m12).** This figure shows the average monthly inflation expectations broken down both by the presidential alliance vs. non-alliance parties that respondents voted for during 2023 national elections and their *ex ante* TV channel preferences. Those who voted for the presidential alliance parties (AKP+MHP) are colored in orange. National and presidential elections took place on 14 May 2023. Source: Authors' calculations based on KUHIES.

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N	Source
Age	39.971	13.277	18	88	9253	KUHIES
Number of households	3.485	1.415	1	10	9253	KUHIES
Not literate	0.014	0.116	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Literate (no diploma)	0.011	0.104	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Primary school	0.186	0.389	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Secondary school	0.142	0.350	0	1	9253	KUHIES
High school	0.351	0.477	0	1	9253	KUHIES
University (UG)	0.278	0.448	0	1	9253	KUHIES
University (PG)	0.016	0.127	0	1	9253	KUHIES
University (PhD)	0.002	0.039	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Single	0.218	0.413	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Engaged	0.015	0.121	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Married	0.701	0.458	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Widow	0.028	0.165	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Divorced	0.039	0.194	0	1	9253	KUHIES
White collar	0.152	0.359	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Worker	0.328	0.469	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Retired	0.098	0.297	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Housewife	0.327	0.469	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Student	0.044	0.206	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Unemployed	0.051	0.220	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Modern	0.459	0.498	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Traditional	0.412	0.492	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Religious	0.129	0.336	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Turkish	0.860	0.347	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Kurdish	0.129	0.336	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Zaza	0.003	0.055	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Arabic	0.004	0.062	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Atheist	0.012	0.109	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Non-believer	0.019	0.138	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Believer	0.368	0.482	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Religious	0.571	0.495	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Very religious	0.030	0.171	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Household income (10.000 TL ve altı)	0.051	0.221	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Household income (10.001 - 15.000 TL)	0.061	0.240	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Household income (15.001 - 20.000 TL)	0.172	0.377	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Household income (20.001 - 30.000 TL)	0.225	0.417	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Household income (30.001 - 50.000 TL)	0.326	0.469	0	1	9253	KUHIES
Household income (50.001 TL ve üstü)	0.165	0.371	0	1	9253	KUHIES

Table D1: **Summary Statistics for Control Variables in KUHIES.** This table reports summary statistics for demographic and socioeconomic characteristics from the KUHIES survey. Age and number of households are continuous variables capturing respondents' age and household size, respectively. All other variables are binary indicators taking the value one if the respondent belongs to the specified category.

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N	Source
Inflation-related optimism on TV (± 15 words around “Inflation”)	-0.330	0.504	-1	1	9012	YouTube & Dailymotion
Inflation-related optimism on TV (± 50 words around “Inflation”)	-0.267	0.581	-1	1	9012	YouTube & Dailymotion
Inflation-related optimism on TV (Base BERT)	-0.349	0.429	-1	1	9012	YouTube & Dailymotion
Inflation-related optimism on TV (Few-shot Qwen2.5-14B)	-0.635	0.363	-1	1	9012	YouTube & Dailymotion
Inflation-related optimism on TV (Zero-shot Qwen2.5-14B)	-0.575	0.267	-1	0	9012	YouTube & Dailymotion
“Economy” mentions on TV	0.032	0.022	0	0	9253	YouTube & Dailymotion
“Growth” mentions on TV	0.003	0.003	0	0	9253	YouTube & Dailymotion
“Unemployment” mentions on TV	0.004	0.004	0	0	9253	YouTube & Dailymotion
“Export” mentions on TV	0.003	0.004	0	0	9253	YouTube & Dailymotion
“Tax” mentions on TV	0.039	0.037	0	0	9253	YouTube & Dailymotion

Table D2: **Summary Statistics for Additional Variables in Robustness Checks.**

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome →	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV	3.376*** [0.395]	2.857*** [0.387]	1.597*** [0.483]	1.199** [0.545]	1.838*** [0.584]	1.596*** [0.584]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party × Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province × Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	8,545	8,545	8,545	8,545	8,545	8,545

Table D3: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [across identical samples]. The table summarizes the results of equation 1 estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. Each regression is estimated across identical (i.e., overlapping) samples. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\longrightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>Language Model: Base BERT</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	1.593*** [0.367]	2.070*** [0.398]	1.496*** [0.468]	0.900* [0.545]	1.489** [0.599]	1.333** [0.601]
Inflation-related Sentiment on TV	-0.129*** [0.029]	-0.063** [0.032]	0.118*** [0.040]	-0.013 [0.047]	-0.036 [0.051]	-0.049 [0.051]
Observations	11,617	9,012	8,943	8,943	8,415	8,319
<i>Language Model: Zero-shot Qwen2.5-14B</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.441*** [0.363]	2.550*** [0.370]	1.570*** [0.468]	0.899 [0.547]	1.446** [0.598]	1.278** [0.597]
Inflation-related Optimism on TV	-0.090** [0.037]	-0.019 [0.038]	0.082*** [0.031]	0.005 [0.032]	-0.025 [0.035]	-0.028 [0.037]
Observations	11,617	9,012	8,943	8,943	8,415	8,319
<i>Language Model: Few-shot Qwen2.5-14B</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.086*** [0.357]	2.402*** [0.374]	1.589*** [0.467]	0.899* [0.545]	1.475** [0.598]	1.305** [0.597]
Inflation-related Optimism on TV	-0.104*** [0.028]	-0.034 [0.030]	0.074*** [0.028]	0.020 [0.030]	0.027 [0.033]	0.009 [0.032]
Observations	11,617	9,012	8,943	8,943	8,415	8,319
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Table D4: **Inflation Mentions & Sentiment/Optimism on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [with alternative language models]. See the notes in Table 3 for details and Table D2 for summary statistics. This robustness check reproduces Table 3 by using alternative languages models that compute sentiment/optimism scores as described in Online Appendix C. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome →	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV x Inflation-related Optimism on TV	-1.645* [0.943]	-0.881 [0.997]	2.726** [1.117]	2.024* [1.163]	1.411 [1.333]	1.675 [1.293]
Inflation mentions on TV	0.726 [0.671]	1.461* [0.748]	3.235*** [0.796]	2.212*** [0.845]	2.316** [0.928]	2.324*** [0.853]
Inflation-related Optimism on TV	-0.058** [0.027]	-0.039 [0.029]	0.010 [0.032]	-0.050 [0.034]	-0.047 [0.036]	-0.070* [0.037]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party × Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province × Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	11,617	9,012	8,943	8,943	8,415	8,319

Table D5: **Interaction of Inflation Mentions & Optimism on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations.** See the notes in Table 3 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 3 by additionally including an interaction term between *Inflation mentions on TV* and *Inflation-related Optimism on TV*. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Outcome →	<i>Inflation mentions on TV (next month)</i>			
Perceived Past Inflation	0.055*** [0.018]	0.069*** [0.019]	-0.016 [0.013]	-0.004 [0.014]
Channel FE	No	No	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	Yes	No	Yes
Observations	96	96	96	96

Table D6: **Perceived Past Inflation and Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News in the Next Month.** The table summarizes the results of a channel-level regression estimated over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. Dependent variable is *Inflation Mentions on TV*, defined as the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month. *Perceived Past Inflation* is a continuous variable measuring past-12-month inflation estimate averaged over respondents watching a particular TV channel in a given month (lagged by a month). Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table D2 for summary statistics. Robust standard errors are clustered at the channel-level level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome →	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	(2SLS)	(First stage)	(2SLS)	(First stage)	(2SLS)	(First stage)
	Inf.Expectations	Inf.Mentions	Inf.Expectations	Inf.Mentions	Inf.Expectations	Inf.Mentions
Inflation mentions on TV	0.180 [0.412]		11.033*** [4.093]		9.235*** [2.859]	
Distance to election (in months)		0.014*** [0.000]		0.002*** [0.000]		0.003*** [0.000]
CPI inflation rate	-0.001*** [0.000]	0.003*** [0.000]	-0.002** [0.001]	0.000*** [0.000]	-0.003*** [0.001]	0.001*** [0.000]
Election mentions on TV	0.004*** [0.001]	0.002*** [0.000]	-0.056** [0.022]	0.005*** [0.000]	-0.019*** [0.007]	0.002*** [0.000]
Perceived Past Inflation	0.703*** [0.017]	0.006*** [0.001]	0.669*** [0.025]	0.003*** [0.001]	0.535*** [0.026]	0.000 [0.001]
Individual controls	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Observations	9,547	9,547	7,227	7,227	7,132	7,132
First-stage Kleibergen-Paap F-stat		2480.84		29.61		117.92
First-stage Montiel-Pflueger F-stat		2480.84		31.21		216.7

Table D7: ***Instrumented Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations*** · [controlling for perceived past inflation]. The table summarizes the results of 2SLS estimations over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is instrumented with *Distance to election (in months)* which measures the number of months between a survey wave and the local elections that took place in March, 2024. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. *Inflation Mentions on TV* is the number of “inflation” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). *CPI inflation rate* is the monthly CPI inflation rate and *Election Mentions on TV* is the number of “election” words mentioned by a particular TV channel, averaged over all available daily prime-time news programs of that channel in a given month (lagged by a month). *Perceived Past Inflation* is as a continuous variable measuring past-12-month inflation estimates of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. Prime-time TV news videos and transcripts have been sourced from publicly available platforms (YouTube & Dailymotion). See Table 1 for summary statistics and Table D1 for the individual-level control variables. For the detailed construction of the data, see Section 3. First-stage Montiel–Pflueger F -stat tests for weak instruments in the first-stage estimation are implemented in a way that is robust to heteroskedasticity, autocorrelation, and clustering. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Sample →	<i>Prefer to watch news on TV</i>			<i>Not prefer to watch news on TV</i>		
Outcome →	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Distance to election (in months)	0.007*** [0.002]	0.015*** [0.003]	0.015*** [0.003]	-0.001 [0.005]	0.008 [0.006]	0.002 [0.007]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes
Observations	11,663	8,993	8,936	2,128	1,579	1,570

Table D8: **Distance to Election (in months) and Inflation Expectations · [reduced-form]**. The table summarizes the results of reduced-form OLS estimations over the full sample period from January-2024 to December-2024, separately for the subsamples of respondents who prefer to watch news on TV and those who do not. *Distance to election (in months)* measures the number of months between a survey wave and the local elections that took place in March, 2024. Dependent variable is *Inflation Expectations*, defined as a continuous variable measuring 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in KUHIES surveys. See Table D2 for summary statistics and Section 3 for the detailed construction of the data. Robust standard errors are clustered at the individual level and reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\longrightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>(Baseline)</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
“Economy” mentions on TV	4.254*** [0.522]	3.453*** [0.550]	2.307*** [0.669]	1.034 [0.687]	0.939 [0.714]	0.880 [0.746]
“Growth” mentions on TV	0.460 [2.659]	1.893 [2.961]	4.193 [3.050]	1.303 [3.379]	0.329 [3.303]	2.782 [3.332]
“Unemployment” mentions on TV	16.436*** [2.196]	13.212*** [2.309]	-3.855 [2.466]	-1.096 [3.084]	-0.779 [3.858]	-1.948 [3.801]
“Export” mentions on TV	-0.910 [1.778]	-1.371 [1.794]	1.162 [1.757]	0.452 [1.923]	0.169 [2.094]	1.366 [2.082]
“Tax” mentions on TV	2.418*** [0.285]	2.158*** [0.283]	0.993*** [0.248]	0.202 [0.340]	0.357 [0.435]	0.596 [0.461]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545

Table D9: **Placebo Tests of Other Economic Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations.** See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by changing the keyword mentioned on the prime-time TV news. See Table D2 for summary statistics. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome →	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
Inflation mentions on TV	2.545*** [0.274]	2.184*** [0.311]	1.106*** [0.323]	0.714* [0.388]	1.479*** [0.489]	1.514*** [0.493]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party × Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province × Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545

Table D10: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [without sample weights]. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by estimating the regressions without using the sample weights in KUHIES. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\longrightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>2.5% removed from both tails</i>						
<i>(Baseline)</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545
<i>1% removed from both tails</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.289*** [0.456]	3.043*** [0.480]	1.505** [0.612]	0.726 [0.715]	1.273* [0.738]	1.204* [0.730]
Observations	12,246	9,517	9,458	9,458	8,896	8,802
<i>5% removed from both tails</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.288*** [0.273]	2.122*** [0.302]	1.262*** [0.325]	0.649 [0.404]	1.176** [0.461]	1.061** [0.462]
Observations	11,055	8,601	8,521	8,521	8,010	7,902
<i>With Huber weights</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.167*** [0.167]	1.744*** [0.187]	0.935*** [0.215]	0.435 [0.266]	0.915*** [0.328]	1.063*** [0.338]
Observations	11,918	9,283	9,218	9,218	8,657	8,560
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Table D11: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [with alternative ways of removing outliers]. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by using different thresholds/methods in removing the outliers for the dependent variable. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\longrightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>Clustering at individual-level (Baseline)</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
<i>Clustering at province-level</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.412]	2.787*** [0.421]	1.655*** [0.308]	1.152*** [0.368]	1.778*** [0.455]	1.596*** [0.450]
<i>Clustering at channel-level</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.424]	2.787*** [0.373]	1.655*** [0.343]	1.152** [0.503]	1.778* [0.838]	1.596* [0.745]
<i>Clustering at party-level</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.244*** [0.543]	2.886*** [0.312]	1.681*** [0.409]	1.216*** [0.240]	1.778*** [0.189]	1.596*** [0.206]
<i>Clustering at channel x party-level</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.244*** [0.548]	2.886*** [0.495]	1.681*** [0.383]	1.216*** [0.402]	1.778*** [0.492]	1.596*** [0.434]
<i>Double clustering at channel and party levels</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.244*** [0.417]	2.886 [0.000]	1.681*** [0.370]	1.216** [0.374]	1.778** [0.700]	1.596** [0.637]
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545

Table D12: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations · [with alternative ways of clustering standard errors]**. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by clustering standard errors at different levels of aggregation. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\longrightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>Wild bootstrap clustering at channel-level</i>						
Bootstrap p-value for <i>Inflation mentions on TV</i>	0.01	0.01	0.08	0.07	0.08	0.08
<i>Wild bootstrap clustering at party-level</i>						
Bootstrap p-value for <i>Inflation mentions on TV</i>	0.02	0.01	0.05	0.03	0.00	0.01
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545

Table D13: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [with wild cluster bootstrap procedure for levels with few clusters]. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by using the wild cluster bootstrap procedure (Cameron et al., 2008) for standard errors. The six-point Webb distribution (MacKinnon and Webb, 2018) is employed and the bootstrap p-values are reported for each estimate.

Outcome →	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>Restricting to individuals with at least 5 observations (Baseline)</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545
<i>Restricting to individuals with at least 4 observations</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.903*** [0.326]	2.566*** [0.341]	1.528*** [0.438]	0.975** [0.494]	1.565*** [0.554]	1.381** [0.555]
Observations	13,190	10,215	10,121	10,121	9,485	9,382
<i>Restricting to individuals with at least 6 observations</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.181*** [0.387]	2.881*** [0.394]	1.660*** [0.507]	1.244** [0.582]	1.854*** [0.642]	1.853*** [0.661]
Observations	10,434	8,171	8,133	8,133	7,691	7,575
<i>Unrestricted</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.763*** [0.286]	2.342*** [0.309]	1.387*** [0.425]	0.764 [0.485]	1.248** [0.558]	0.991* [0.554]
Observations	15,390	11,843	11,479	11,479	10,690	10,590
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party × Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province × Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Table D14: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations · [with alternative ways of balancing the sample]**. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by using different thresholds in producing a balanced panel of individuals over time. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\longrightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>Unrestricted (Baseline)</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545
<i>Restricting to a minimum of 5 transcripts per channel-month</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.982*** [0.353]	2.709*** [0.369]	1.652*** [0.465]	0.970* [0.539]	1.518** [0.596]	1.301** [0.594]
Observations	11,573	8,975	8,910	8,910	8,384	8,285
<i>Restricting to a minimum of 10 transcripts per channel-month</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.747*** [0.364]	2.528*** [0.368]	1.568*** [0.469]	0.818 [0.572]	1.377** [0.623]	1.093* [0.625]
Observations	10,970	8,448	8,359	8,359	7,871	7,772
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Table D15: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations · [with alternative frequencies of news transcripts per channel-month]**. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by restricting the sample to those channel-month observations with a minimum number of transcripts. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Outcome $\longrightarrow$	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>No channel switching</i>						
<i>(Baseline)</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545
<i>Channel switching allowed</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.517*** [0.369]	3.317*** [0.383]	1.271*** [0.434]	0.851** [0.432]	1.211*** [0.430]	0.702 [0.458]
Observations	7,207	6,226	5,950	5,950	5,658	5,505
<i>Channel switching allowed with Huber weights</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	2.583*** [0.175]	2.258*** [0.186]	0.837*** [0.200]	0.432* [0.224]	0.720*** [0.253]	0.669** [0.266]
Observations	7,230	6,231	5,955	5,955	5,657	5,506
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Table D16: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations** · [when channel switching is allowed]. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by allowing for individuals' channel switching over time rather than using their *ex ante* channel preferences. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Outcome $\longrightarrow$	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	<i>Inflation Expectations (next month)</i>					
<i>Individuals allocated to the first preferred channel (Baseline)</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.050*** [0.351]	2.787*** [0.366]	1.655*** [0.464]	1.152** [0.523]	1.778*** [0.579]	1.596*** [0.584]
Observations	11,887	9,253	9,188	9,188	8,644	8,545
<i>Individuals allocated to the most frequently preferred channel</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.223*** [0.359]	3.062*** [0.371]	1.651*** [0.496]	1.267** [0.627]	2.240*** [0.691]	1.524** [0.744]
Observations	11,646	9,025	8,965	8,965	8,436	8,330
<i>Individuals allocated to the most frequently preferred channel and frequent switchers dropped</i>						
Inflation mentions on TV	3.489*** [0.377]	3.178*** [0.387]	1.636*** [0.531]	1.629** [0.641]	2.860*** [0.734]	2.004** [0.829]
Observations	10,392	8,069	8,016	8,016	7,539	7,425
Individual controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Individual FE	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Time FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	No
Party $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Province $\times$ Time FE	No	No	No	No	No	Yes

Table D17: **Inflation Mentions on Prime-time TV News and Inflation Expectations · [with alternative ways of allocating individuals to channels]**. See the notes in Table 2 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 2 by allocating individuals to their most frequently preferred channel and dropping frequent channel switchers defined as individuals whose most frequently preferred channel over our sample period has been preferred less than 50% of the time. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

Appendix E - Robustness Checks (RCT)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)	(11)	(12)	(13)
Outcome →	Male	Age	Tertiary Education	Secondary Education	High Income	Employed	Modern	Gov't-channel Viewer	Opp'n-channel Viewer	Neutral-channel Viewer	AKPvote2023	CHPvote2023	Perceived Past Inflation
Positive slant (gov't TV)	-0.008 [0.022]	-1.848** [0.725]	0.037* [0.021]	-0.037* [0.020]	-0.011 [0.022]	-0.001 [0.020]	-0.023 [0.022]	0.005 [0.017]	-0.021 [0.019]	-0.016 [0.017]	0.002 [0.020]	0.007 [0.019]	0.109 [0.714]
Positive slant (neutral TV)	-0.003 [0.022]	-1.130 [0.721]	0.038* [0.021]	-0.015 [0.020]	0.004 [0.022]	0.008 [0.020]	-0.028 [0.022]	-0.004 [0.017]	0.015 [0.019]	-0.015 [0.017]	-0.013 [0.020]	0.012 [0.019]	-0.839 [0.684]
Negative slant (neutral TV)	0.031 [0.022]	-1.716** [0.727]	0.032 [0.021]	-0.007 [0.020]	0.014 [0.022]	0.051** [0.020]	-0.041* [0.022]	-0.011 [0.017]	-0.033* [0.019]	-0.017 [0.017]	-0.013 [0.020]	-0.007 [0.019]	0.125 [0.701]
Negative slant (opp'n TV)	-0.005 [0.022]	-0.947 [0.717]	0.051** [0.021]	-0.015 [0.020]	0.030 [0.022]	0.022 [0.020]	-0.015 [0.022]	0.032* [0.018]	-0.004 [0.019]	-0.014 [0.017]	-0.023 [0.020]	-0.010 [0.019]	-1.074 [0.711]
Positive slant (no logo)	-0.023 [0.022]	-1.001 [0.735]	0.006 [0.020]	0.012 [0.020]	0.001 [0.022]	0.013 [0.020]	-0.021 [0.022]	0.026 [0.018]	-0.021 [0.019]	-0.034** [0.016]	-0.020 [0.020]	0.002 [0.019]	0.295 [0.617]
Negative slant (no logo)	-0.004 [0.022]	-0.829 [0.733]	-0.023 [0.020]	0.007 [0.020]	0.017 [0.022]	0.033* [0.020]	-0.034 [0.022]	0.012 [0.017]	-0.038** [0.019]	0.013 [0.017]	0.008 [0.020]	-0.005 [0.019]	-0.249 [0.617]
Placebo	0.021 [0.022]	-1.090 [0.751]	-0.022 [0.020]	0.016 [0.020]	-0.003 [0.022]	0.010 [0.020]	-0.030 [0.022]	-0.014 [0.017]	-0.010 [0.019]	-0.026 [0.017]	-0.046** [0.020]	-0.029 [0.019]	0.192 [0.615]
Control group	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news	No news
Control mean	0.499	45.192	0.325	0.305	0.551	0.687	0.526	0.196	0.267	0.185	0.310	0.251	54.602
F-stat	1.214	1.220	3.843	1.528	0.750	1.614	0.677	1.751	1.754	1.489	1.482	0.867	0.947
Observations	8,333	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338	8,338

Table E1: **Randomized Control Trial: Balance Tests.** The table summarizes the results of estimations in which pre-treatment variables are regressed on the full set of treatment indicators with those not receiving any news treatment serving as the control group. See Section 4 for the construction of treatment indicators, Table 1 for summary statistics and Table E2 for the individual-level control variables. Robust standard errors are reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N	Source
Male	0.508	0.500	0	1	8154	RCT
Age	44.298	16.847	18	85	8159	RCT
Tertiary education	0.322	0.467	0	1	8159	RCT
Secondary education	0.303	0.460	0	1	8159	RCT
High income	0.561	0.496	0	1	8159	RCT
Employed	0.705	0.456	0	1	8159	RCT
Modern	0.497	0.500	0	1	8159	RCT
Voted for AKP in 2023	0.304	0.460	0	1	8159	RCT
Voted for CHP in 2023	0.237	0.426	0	1	8159	RCT

Table E2: **Summary Statistics for Control Variables in RCT.** This table reports summary statistics for demographic and socioeconomic characteristics from the RCT survey.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Outcome →	<i>Posterior</i>				
Prior × Positive slant (Pro-gov't TV logo)	-0.055*** [0.019]	-0.140*** [0.048]	-0.155*** [0.049]	-0.024 [0.040]	0.004 [0.032]
Prior × Positive slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.005 [0.018]	0.012 [0.048]	-0.111*** [0.041]	0.065 [0.040]	0.013 [0.029]
Prior × Negative slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.034* [0.018]	-0.074 [0.051]	-0.128*** [0.044]	-0.052 [0.048]	-0.001 [0.028]
Prior × Negative slant (Pro-opp'n TV logo)	-0.007 [0.018]	0.020 [0.053]	-0.109** [0.043]	0.014 [0.037]	0.003 [0.028]
Prior × Positive slant (No TV logo)	-0.028 [0.019]	0.035 [0.047]	-0.146*** [0.046]	-0.025 [0.046]	-0.021 [0.031]
Prior × Negative slant (No TV logo)	-0.039** [0.020]	-0.053 [0.051]	-0.150*** [0.050]	-0.005 [0.047]	-0.041 [0.032]
Prior × Placebo text (No TV logo)	-0.023 [0.019]	-0.085 [0.052]	-0.027 [0.041]	0.034 [0.044]	-0.036 [0.029]
Prior	0.886*** [0.013]	0.877*** [0.037]	0.940*** [0.032]	0.841*** [0.030]	0.892*** [0.021]
Sample of channel viewers	All	Pro-gov't channel	Neutral channel	Pro-opp'n channel	Non-viewer
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Baseline treatments controlled	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	8,152	1,665	1,401	2,064	3,024

Table E3: **Randomized Control Trial (RCT): Exposure to Media Slant and Inflation Expectations · [with individual-level controls]**. See the notes in Table 9 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table 9 by controlling for individual characteristics listed in Table E2. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Outcome →	<i>Posterior</i>				
Prior × Positive slant (Pro-gov't TV logo)	-0.031 [0.036]	-0.291*** [0.077]	-0.216* [0.127]	-0.062 [0.049]	0.022 [0.129]
Prior × Positive slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.013 [0.038]	-0.231*** [0.078]	-0.166 [0.142]	0.065 [0.053]	0.027 [0.113]
Prior × Negative slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.050 [0.034]	0.029 [0.056]	-0.757*** [0.089]	-0.033 [0.064]	0.086 [0.116]
Prior × Negative slant (Pro-opp'n TV logo)	-0.028 [0.034]	0.031 [0.056]	-0.743*** [0.089]	-0.030 [0.043]	-0.025 [0.133]
Prior	0.929*** [0.026]	0.834*** [0.046]	0.757*** [0.089]	0.951*** [0.030]	0.778*** [0.105]
Sample of channel viewers	All	Pro-gov't channel	Neutral channel	Pro-opp'n channel	Non-viewer
Baseline treatments controlled	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,434	469	272	526	190

Table E4: **Pilot Experiment: Exposure to Media Slant and Inflation Expectations.** The table summarizes the results of equation 2 estimated over the full pilot sample as well as subsamples of viewers preferring TV channels of different political alignments. Dependent variable is *Posterior*, defined as a continuous variable measuring the post-treatment 12-month-ahead inflation expectations of respondents included in the pilot experiment. *Prior* is a continuous variable measuring the pre-treatment 12-month-ahead inflation expectations (mode) of respondents included in the pilot experiment. See Section 4 for the construction of treatment indicators, Table 1 for summary statistics and Table E5 for the individual-level control variables. All regressions are estimated with Huber weights and robust standard errors are reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N	Source
Posterior	49.248	32.565	0	400	1438	Pilot
Prior	47.251	32.814	0	400	1438	Pilot
Positive slant (Pro-gov't TV logo)	0.199	0.399	0	1	1438	Pilot
Positive slant (Neutral TV logo)	0.197	0.398	0	1	1438	Pilot
Negative slant (Neutral TV logo)	0.206	0.404	0	1	1438	Pilot
Negative slant (Pro-opp'n TV logo)	0.198	0.399	0	1	1438	Pilot
Placebo text (No TV logo)	0.200	0.400	0	1	1438	Pilot
Pro-gov't channel	0.325	0.469	0	1	1438	Pilot
Neutral channel	0.186	0.389	0	1	1438	Pilot
Pro-opp'n channel	0.359	0.480	0	1	1438	Pilot
Non-viewer	0.129	0.336	0	1	1438	Pilot
Male	0.506	0.500	0	1	1438	Pilot
Age btw 30-49	0.391	0.488	0	1	1438	Pilot
Age above 50	0.374	0.484	0	1	1438	Pilot
Tertiary education	0.335	0.472	0	1	1438	Pilot
Secondary education	0.574	0.495	0	1	1438	Pilot
High income	0.443	0.497	0	1	1438	Pilot
Employed	0.631	0.483	0	1	1438	Pilot

Table E5: **Summary Statistics for the Pilot Experiment.** This table reports summary statistics for the pilot survey.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
Outcome →	Male	Age30-49	Age50plus	Tertiary Education	Secondary Education	High Income	Employed	Gov't-channel Viewer	Opp'n-channel Viewer	Neutral-channel Viewer
Positive slant (Pro-gov't TV logo)	-0.078* [0.040]	-0.009 [0.039]	-0.009 [0.039]	-0.035 [0.038]	0.026 [0.040]	-0.003 [0.040]	0.016 [0.039]	-0.022 [0.038]	-0.002 [0.039]	-0.001 [0.031]
Positive slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.030 [0.041]	0.016 [0.040]	-0.024 [0.039]	-0.037 [0.038]	0.037 [0.040]	0.023 [0.040]	0.011 [0.040]	-0.021 [0.038]	0.035 [0.039]	0.008 [0.032]
Negative slant (Neutral TV logo)	0.003 [0.040]	-0.008 [0.039]	0.008 [0.039]	-0.030 [0.038]	0.019 [0.040]	-0.009 [0.040]	0.028 [0.039]	-0.030 [0.038]	-0.050 [0.038]	0.027 [0.032]
Negative slant (Pro-opp'n TV logo)	-0.015 [0.041]	0.001 [0.040]	-0.018 [0.039]	-0.032 [0.038]	0.015 [0.040]	0.015 [0.040]	0.028 [0.039]	-0.048 [0.038]	0.054 [0.039]	-0.036 [0.030]
Control group	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo	Placebo
Control mean	0.518	0.387	0.377	0.351	0.570	0.423	0.610	0.341	0.361	0.184
F-stat	1.351	0.127	0.224	0.314	0.231	0.209	0.186	0.428	2.148	1.110
Observations	1,528	1,528	1,528	1,528	1,528	1,528	1,528	1,528	1,528	1,528

Table E6: **Pilot Experiment: Balance Tests.** The table summarizes the results of estimations in which pre-treatment variables are regressed on the full set of treatment indicators with those receiving placebo treatment text serving as the control group. See Section 4 for the construction of treatment indicators and Table E5 for the individual-level control variables. Robust standard errors are reported in brackets. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Outcome →	<i>Posterior</i>				
Prior × Positive slant (Pro-gov't TV logo)	-0.038 [0.035]	-0.280*** [0.081]	-0.261** [0.125]	-0.069 [0.046]	0.012 [0.140]
Prior × Positive slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.029 [0.038]	-0.200** [0.090]	-0.292** [0.135]	0.012 [0.058]	0.029 [0.129]
Prior × Negative slant (Neutral TV logo)	-0.051 [0.034]	-0.061 [0.087]	-0.236** [0.118]	-0.110* [0.065]	0.090 [0.130]
Prior × Negative slant (Pro-opp'n TV logo)	-0.038 [0.034]	0.126 [0.080]	-0.597*** [0.094]	-0.086* [0.046]	-0.007 [0.150]
Prior	0.942*** [0.026]	0.635*** [0.070]	0.801*** [0.088]	0.957*** [0.033]	0.751*** [0.118]
Sample of channel viewers	All	Pro-gov't channel	Neutral channel	Pro-opp'n channel	Non-viewer
Individual controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Baseline treatments controlled	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,434	475	272	526	192

Table E7: **Pilot Experiment: Exposure to Media Slant and Inflation Expectations** · [with individual-level controls]. See the notes in Table E4 for details. This robustness check reproduces Table E4 by controlling for individual characteristics listed in Table E5. *Significant at 10%; **significant at 5%; ***significant at 1%.